inequality, the government has implemented targeted initiatives across education, health, and social protection. In educational efforts, the focus is on ensuring the availability, quality, and equitable distribution of educational programmes, particularly to those who need them most. In health, measures include public investment to provide affordable preventive and curative care, nutrition, and health insurance. These measures have been discussed in detail in Chapter 11 of the Economic Survey. Government measures also focus on inclusion and accessibility for persons with disabilities, including targeted economic and entrepreneurial support, digital and technological empowerment, and the development of social justice and legal frameworks. These steps are designed to reduce structural barriers, empower marginalised groups, and create pathways for all citizens to improve their socio-economic status.

13.4. The focus of the government is also on making available and financing, where required, skills development, especially in the present context of technology-driven disruption to jobs and skills. As digitalisation and the use of AI (artificial intelligence) continue to reshape work, workers and employers are entering into more flexible work relationships. This has taken the form of a flourishing gig economy. There is a need to support those engaged in the economy through specific social protection measures. These are discussed in Chapter 12 of the Economic Survey.

13.5. Against this background, this chapter examines the country's progress across key social indicators. The first section reviews achievements in reducing poverty and inequality. The second section examines trends in government social sector expenditure. The third section focuses on recent developments in the rural economy, highlighting the contributions of communities, the integration of technology, and capacity building to economic growth. The final section examines how social justice initiatives promote ongoing inclusion as India progresses on its development path.

LIFTING MILLIONS UP: PROGRESS ON POVERTY AND INEQUALITY

13.6. Poverty and inequality are important issues for any developing country. The state endeavours to ensure equality of opportunities, eliminate absolute poverty, and prevent inequality from rising. It aspires for and works towards the goal that everyone in society has a fair chance to fulfil their potential, regardless of their socio-economic background, the origin of their parents, or geographical location. Policies such as income support, social protection, labour market regulation, and education for all help the state in its endeavour to ensure the goals of upward social mobility across generations and throughout an individual's lifespan. For example, enhancing access to educational opportunities throughout a person's life is a crucial factor that acts as a powerful 'equaliser' of chances to improve one's life.

13.7. These aspirations and policy efforts are commonly assessed using benchmarks of poverty and deprivation. One such metric is the World Bank's (WB) International Poverty Line (IPL), which represents the minimum amount of money a person needs per day to afford basic necessities such as food, clothing, and shelter. In June 2025, the WB raised the poverty line from USD 2.15 to USD 3.00 a day, adjusted for the purchasing power of money to 2021 prices.[1]

13.8. With the revised IPL, the poverty rates for India in 2022-23 are 5.3 per cent for extreme poverty and 23.9 per cent for lower-middle-income poverty.[2] According to the WB, India has made significant strides in reducing non-monetary poverty. The WB Multidimensional Poverty Measure for India stood at 15.5 per cent in 2022-23, reflecting ongoing improvements in living conditions.[3] These estimates corroborate the estimates of the Multidimensional Poverty Index (MPI) as measured by NITI Aayog.[4] The index measures non-monetary poverty by considering factors such as education, health, and living conditions. It shows a decline from 55.3 per cent in 2005-06[5] to 14.96 per cent by 2019-21[6], and is estimated to have decreased further to 11.28 per cent in 2022-23.

13.9. Alongside the WB poverty estimates, poverty estimates by researchers based on the Tendulkar committee poverty line also indicate a sharp and broad-based decline in poverty in India. Between 2011-12 and 2023-24, sustained economic growth, supported by redistributive interventions, is estimated to have reduced the poverty rate from 21.9 per cent in 2011-12 to 4.7 per cent in 2022-23 and further to 2.3 per cent in 2023-24.[7] The estimates indicate low poverty incidence across states and in both rural and urban areas. These achievements demonstrate the government's commitment to inclusive development by targeting both rural and urban communities through welfare programmes, economic reforms, and enhanced access to services, thereby significantly reducing poverty.

1 The IPL reflects updated information from new surveys in various countries, including the Household Consumer Expenditure Surveys for India. It uses improved methods for estimating poverty in countries with limited data, and a revised approach to categorising countries. https://tinyurl.com/ys8ntsjd

2 WB India Poverty and Equity Brief: October 2025 (https://tinyurl.com/2f6ytkmf). The poverty estimates are based on the Household Consumption Expenditure Survey (HCES) data collected for August 2022 to July 2023.

3 The World Bank's Multidimensional Poverty Measure is adapted from the OPHI MPI. It includes extreme poverty but excludes deprivation in nutrition and health. OPHI MPI captures the acute deprivations in health, education, and living standards that a person faces simultaneously.

4 Multidimensional Poverty in India Since 2005-06. https://tinyurl.com/ya2rnbxj

5 National Family Health Survey (NFHS) round 3 (2005-06)

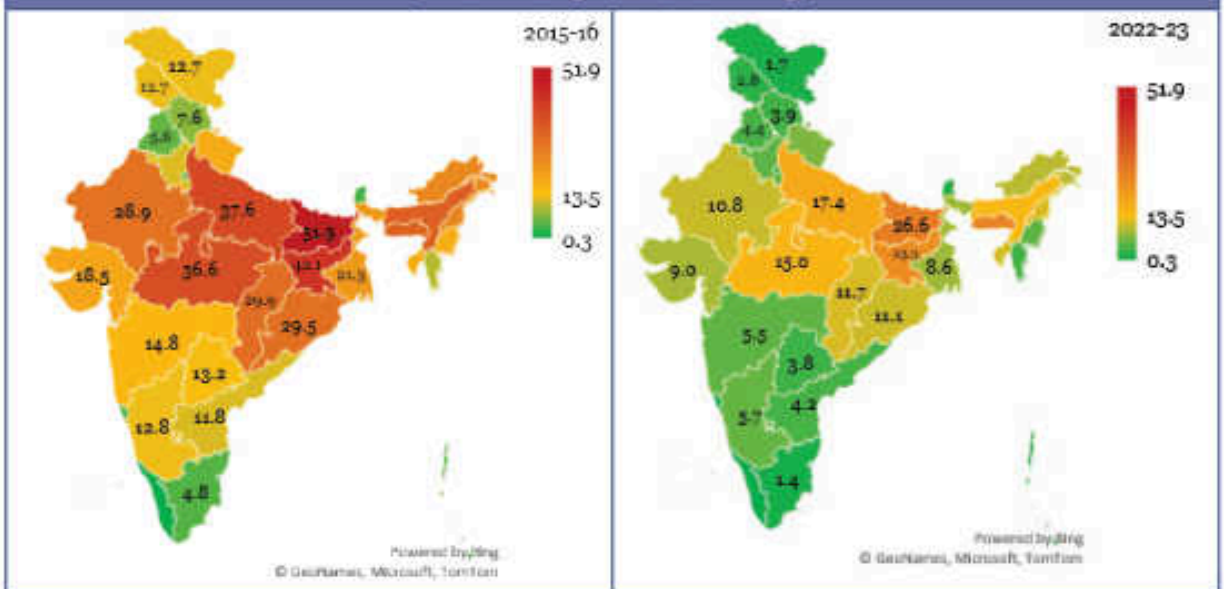
6 NFHS round 5 (2019-21)

7 Panagariya, A., & More, V. (2025). Mapping poverty across social, religious, and economic groups in India. Economic and Political Weekly, 60(48) https://tinyurl.com/44r76e6s

13.10. Alongside the ongoing efforts of the government of India, the state governments have also adopted innovative models and interventions to eradicate poverty and to attain inclusive development. As Chart XIII.1 displays, those states with higher poverty incidence in 2015-16, in terms of MPI, have witnessed a greater reduction in the headcount ratio of poverty[8] over the years, indicating that multidimensional poverty differentials across various states have declined over time.[9]

Chart XIII.1: Progress in state-wise incidence of multidimensional poverty (headcount ratio (per cent))

(From 2015-16 to 2022-23)



Source: Multidimensional Poverty in India since 2005-06, NITI Aayog https://tinyurl.com/ya2rnbxj

13.11. State governments have introduced innovative programmes to tackle poverty over the years. One such example is the Bihar government's 'Satat Jeevikoparjan Yojana (SJY)', a livelihoods scheme targeting ultra-poor women launched in 2018. The programme uses the 'Graduation approach' to support targeted households with asset transfers, capacity-building training, livelihood gap assistance, and mentoring for a period of 24 months, thereby ensuring long-term self-reliance.[10] Beneficiaries were also provided access to insurance, public entitlements, and relief support during crises, such as the COVID-19 pandemic.[11]

13.12. Another example is the Kerala poverty eradication model. The Kerala government implemented a comprehensive method to identify the most vulnerable

8 The Headcount ratio in the MPI shows the percentage of a population that is multidimensionally poor.

9 Ibid note 4 above

10 The 'Graduation approach' is an evidence-informed anti-poverty programme that combines asset transfers, training, financial support, coaching, and health services to address multiple constraints simultaneously.

11 Satat Jeevikoparjan Yojana: https://tinyurl.com/3xzuuk9d

households through extensive community participation, led by local governments and supported by frontline workers, including ASHA (Accredited Social Health Activist), Anganwadi workers, Kudumbashree, and activist groups. Essential documents such as Aadhar, ration cards, Unique Disability ID (UDID) cards for the differently-abled, and electoral IDs, along with emergency services like health insurance and social security pensions, were provided to families. The programme prioritised ensuring basic food and medical care. Individualised micro-plans were created for each family, with regular digital tracking and monitoring service delivery by local self-governments and departments. The Kudumbashree network played a key role as both community monitor and service provider, while local governments prioritised these interventions in their annual development plans.[12] The Union government, through the Ministry of Rural Development, has launched the 'Samaveshi Aajeevika Yojana' programme under the umbrella of Deendayal Antyodaya Yojana – National Rural Livelihoods Mission (DAY-NRLM), as a comprehensive livelihoods programme designed to put rural women on the path to self-sufficiency, built on the 'Graduation approach.'[13]

13.13. Both SJY and the Kerala model showcase the involvement of the community and a multipronged strategy with continuous support and monitoring to 'push' the vulnerable out of the vicious cycle through handholding support, training, access to finance, and basic necessities. These interventions enable households to become self-reliant and resilient even in times of crisis. A study by J-PAL found that SJY beneficiaries reported having a stable income source, even as other income opportunities, like casual labour, disappeared due to COVID-19. [14]

13.14. These state-level innovations reflect broader national priorities, where targeted social investment is being scaled up to support inclusive growth. Understanding trends in social sector expenditure offers insight into the government's approach to enhancing well-being and expanding social protection nationwide.

Social sector expenditure trends

13.15. Inclusive growth based on the principle of 'Sabka Sath, Sabka Vikas, Sabka Vishwas, Sabka Prayas' is the government's model for economic development. The government's efforts to provide affordable housing, social security for workers, food security, financial inclusion, universal access to basic amenities, and high-quality, affordable healthcare are instrumental in improving the overall well-being and standards of living. The Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation's (MoSPI) latest

12 Kerala Extreme Poverty Alleviation Project (EPEP): https://tinyurl.com/4ssapa3y

13 Samaveshi Aajeevika Yojana: https://tinyurl.com/352xb8wk

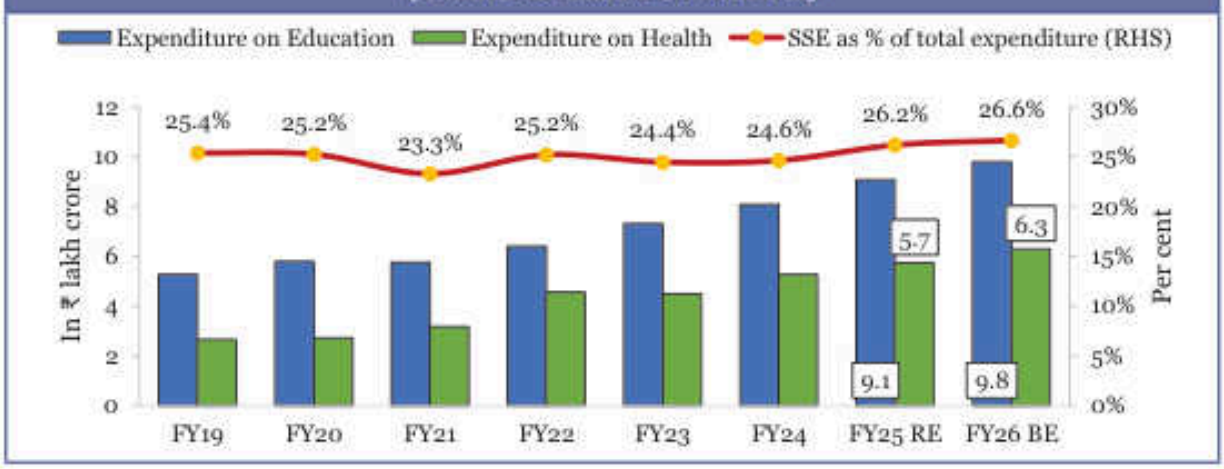
14 The Graduation Approach during the Covid-19 Pandemic: Building Resilience among Ultra-poor Households in Bihar https://tinyurl.com/bdyhc44x

Sustainable Development Goal (SDG) National Indicator Framework (NIF) Progress Report, 2025, provides a comprehensive picture of the impact of these initiatives in achieving a transformative scale-up towards achieving the SDG targets.[15]

13.16. According to the report, the population covered by social protection systems has increased from 22 per cent in 2016 to 64.3 per cent in 2025, indicating a substantial expansion in social security coverage in the country. The population using improved drinking water sources in rural areas has increased from 94.6 per cent in 2015-16 to 99.6 per cent in 2024-25. Universal household electrification was achieved in 2021-22, while 100 per cent of the districts were declared open defecation free (ODF) in 2019-20, and over 96 per cent of Swachh Bharat Mission (SBM) villages have achieved the ODF plus status (As of 31 December 2025).[16]

13.17. Realising the importance of the inclusive developmental goal, the general government's social services expenditure (SSE) has kept pace with the development of the social sector.[17] The general government's SSE has shown a rising trend since FY22. During the five years from FY22 to FY26 (BE), the SSE grew at a compound annual growth rate (CAGR) of 12 per cent. Expenditure on education[18] has grown at a CAGR of 11 per cent, whereas expenditure on health[19] grew at a CAGR of 8 per cent during the same period.

Chart XIII.2 Trends in SSE of the general government (Centre & States combined)



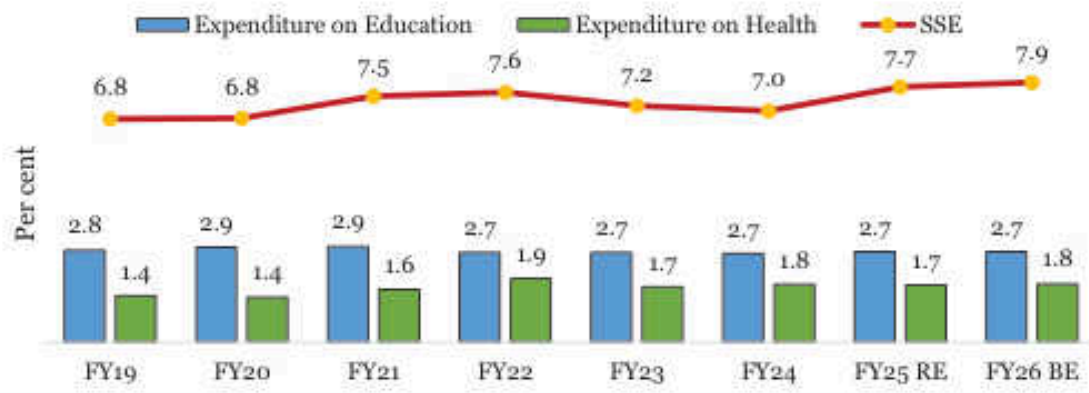
15 SDG National Indicator Framework (NIF) Progress Report, 2025: https://tinyurl.com/9tcb5p4p

16 SBM Grameen Dashboard: https://tinyurl.com/mrxpjpjx

17 Social services include education, sports, art and culture; medical and public health, family welfare; water supply and sanitation; housing; urban development; welfare of SCs, STs and OBCs, labour and labour welfare; social security and welfare, nutrition, relief on account of natural calamities, etc.

18 Expenditure on 'Education' pertains to expenditure on Education, Sports, Arts and Culture.

19 Expenditure on 'Health' includes expenditure on 'Medical and Public Health', 'Family Welfare' and 'Water Supply and Sanitation'.



Source: RBI (RE: Revised Estimates; BE: Budget Estimates)
Note: 1. The expenditure as a percentage of GDP at current market prices is based on the 2011-12 base. 2. The GDP for FY26 is as per the Union Budget FY26.

TRANSFORMING THE RURAL ECONOMY

13.18. Rural development stands at the core of India's journey towards inclusive economic growth, given that a substantial majority of the population continues to reside in rural areas. With 6.65 lakh villages and 2.68 lakh Gram Panchayats (GPs) and Rural Local Bodies, the rural landscape forms the backbone of the nation's social and economic development.[20] While government initiatives have prioritised infrastructure, credit access, basic amenities, and the development of agriculture and traditional industries to make the rural economy self-reliant and resilient, it is the third pillar, the community itself, that holds the key to sustainable transformation. Empowering rural communities and nurturing collective action are essential for inclusive development.

13.19. NABARD's latest Rural Economic Conditions and Sentiments Survey (RECSS) (November 2025) round findings show a broad-based strengthening of rural economic fundamentals, with robust consumption, high income growth, rising investment, improved formal credit access, lower inflation perceptions, better loan repayment conditions, and strong satisfaction with infrastructure, all supported by government welfare transfers and public investment.[21]

13.20. Furthermore, the findings of RECSS are complemented by a recent research report stating that rural consumption has risen to its highest level in 17 quarters.[22] The report attributes this upturn to firm growth in real agricultural and non-agricultural

20 PIB release dated 6 February 2025: https://tinyurl.com/bddttat2

21 NABARD RECSS Round 8 (November 2025): https://tinyurl.com/4jdv4jwp The survey captures quantitative and qualitative data, both backwards-looking (economic conditions) and forward-looking (household sentiments), on a limited set of key macro-financial parameters relating to the rural economy.

22 Piplani, R., & Ladha, T. (7 November 2025). Rural rules, urban follows. Motilal Oswal Financial Services Ltd. https://tinyurl.com/36xfh7h9



Let us understand what Dr Poshita means by this statement.

Have you ever missed a meal? How do you feel when you miss a meal?

We feel tired and less energetic when we do not eat for some time. Why do you think a marathon runner drinks glucose water during and after a race?

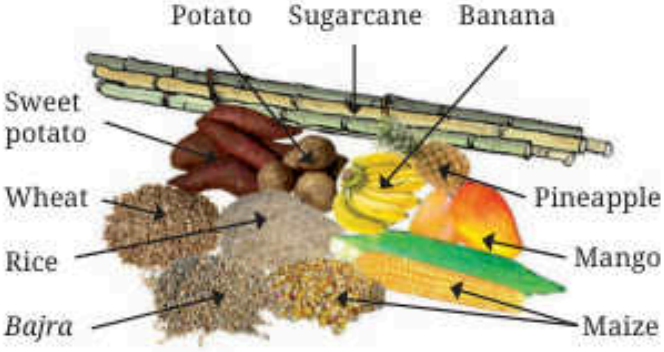


Fig. 3.2: Some sources of carbohydrates

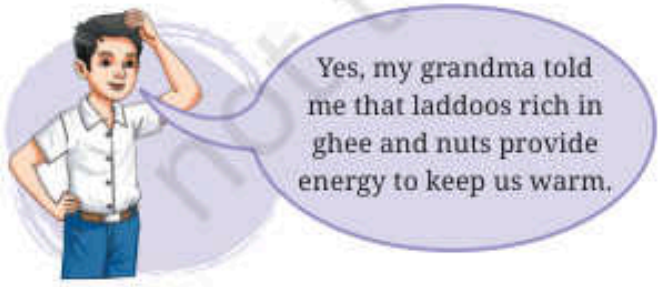
Glucose provides instant energy. Glucose is an example of a carbohydrate. **Carbohydrates** are one of the primary sources of energy in our diet. Cereals like wheat, rice, and maize, vegetables like potato and sweet potato, and fruits like banana, pineapple, and mango are some sources of carbohydrates (Fig. 3.2).

Do you know that common sugar is also a type of carbohydrate?

Why do you think we prefer to have *laddoos* as a part of our traditional diet in winters?



Besan or wheat flour (*aata*) and ghee are among the main ingredients of laddoos along with *goond* (edible gum), nuts, and seeds. Ghee and various kinds of oils are grouped under another kind of food component, which is called **fat**.



Sources of fats can be from plants or animals (Fig. 3.3). Nuts, such as groundnuts, walnuts, coconuts, and almonds, and seeds, such as pumpkin seeds and sunflower seeds, are some sources of fat. Fat is a source of stored energy.

Reprint 2026-27



Fig. 3.3: Some sources of fats

Carbohydrates and fats provide us energy for performing various activities. Therefore, they are called **energy-giving foods.** Identify more food items that are rich sources of carbohydrates and fats .

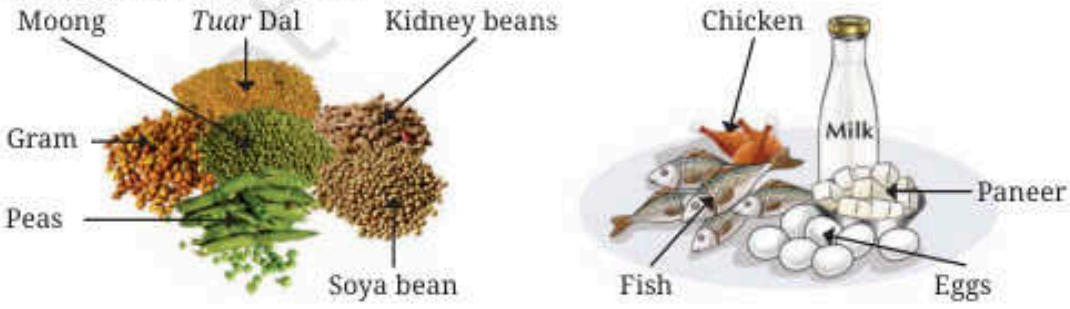


Polar bear

Polar bears accumulate a lot of fat under their skin. This fat serves as an energy source. It supports them during their months-long winter sleep (hibernation), enabling them to survive without eating.

More to know!

Proteins are also an important part of our food. Milk products and pulses are good sources of protein. Sportspersons need proteins in larger quantities to build their muscles. People get proteins from plants as well as animals. Some excellent plant sources of protein are pulses, beans, peas and nuts (Fig. 3.4a). Animal sources of protein are milk, paneer, egg, fish and meat (Fig. 3.4b). Protein-rich foods help in growth and repair of our body. These are, therefore, called **body-building foods**.



(a) Plant sources *(b) Animal sources*

Fig. 3.4: Some sources of proteins

Reprint 2026-27

The right amount of protein must be included in the diet of growing children for their proper growth and development. Which of these food components are part of your daily diet?

More to know!

Have you ever seen mushrooms? They grow mostly in dark and moist places. Edible mushrooms are good sources of protein.



Mushroom

Why do you think we are advised to include servings of fruits, vegetables and other plant-based foods in our daily diet? Let us understand the importance of some other **food components** by reading the following two cases—

Case 1

In earlier times, during long voyages, sailors often suffered from bleeding and swollen gums. During a voyage in 1746, Scottish physician James Lind observed that sailors who consumed lemons and oranges recovered from these symptoms. Bleeding and swollen gums are symptoms of a disease called **scurvy**.

What do you **interpret** by reading Case 1? What cures scurvy? Lemons and oranges help in curing scurvy. Scurvy is caused due to deficiency of Vitamin C. **Vitamin C** present in citrus fruits like lemons and oranges helps in curing this disease.

Case 2



In the 1960s, Indian scientists found that among the human population in the Himalayan region and the Northern plains of India, symptoms of swelling at the front of the neck were prevalent. As per norms of the Government of India, an effort was made to supplement common salt with iodine for preparing **iodised salt**. Consumption of iodised salt visibly reduced the above symptoms. These symptoms were due to a deficiency of iodine in the soil of this region resulting in a lack of iodine in the local food and water supply. Swelling at the front of the neck is a symptom of a disease called **goitre**.

Reprint 2026-27

What do you **infer** from Case 2?

You may have learnt about iodised salt through newspapers, advertisements or by reading about it on a salt packet. What does it mean? Iodised salt is simply common salt mixed with required quantities of salts of iodine.



Salt farming is a traditional practice of a tribal community named *Agariyas*. They practice salt farming in the Little Rann of Kutch and other parts of Gujarat. For eight months, they live in the extreme heat of the desert and work very hard to get salt from seawater.

More to know!

How would you find out more about other food components that protect our body from various diseases?

Activity 3.4: Let us conduct a survey

- Study the chart given in Fig. 3.5 to explore the functions and sources of various food components. Find out more sources of vitamins and minerals. Also, understand the symptoms of the diseases caused by the lack of these food components.
- Visit your neighbourhood, interact with people and find out if any individual shows the symptoms listed on the chart (an investigatory project of this kind can be taken by the students under the guidance of a teacher).
- Correlate these symptoms with their diet and identify the deficiency disease(s) or disorder(s).
- Suggest the possible cause(s) for the symptoms observed and changes required in the diet for improvement.
- Suggest them to visit a doctor for further advice.

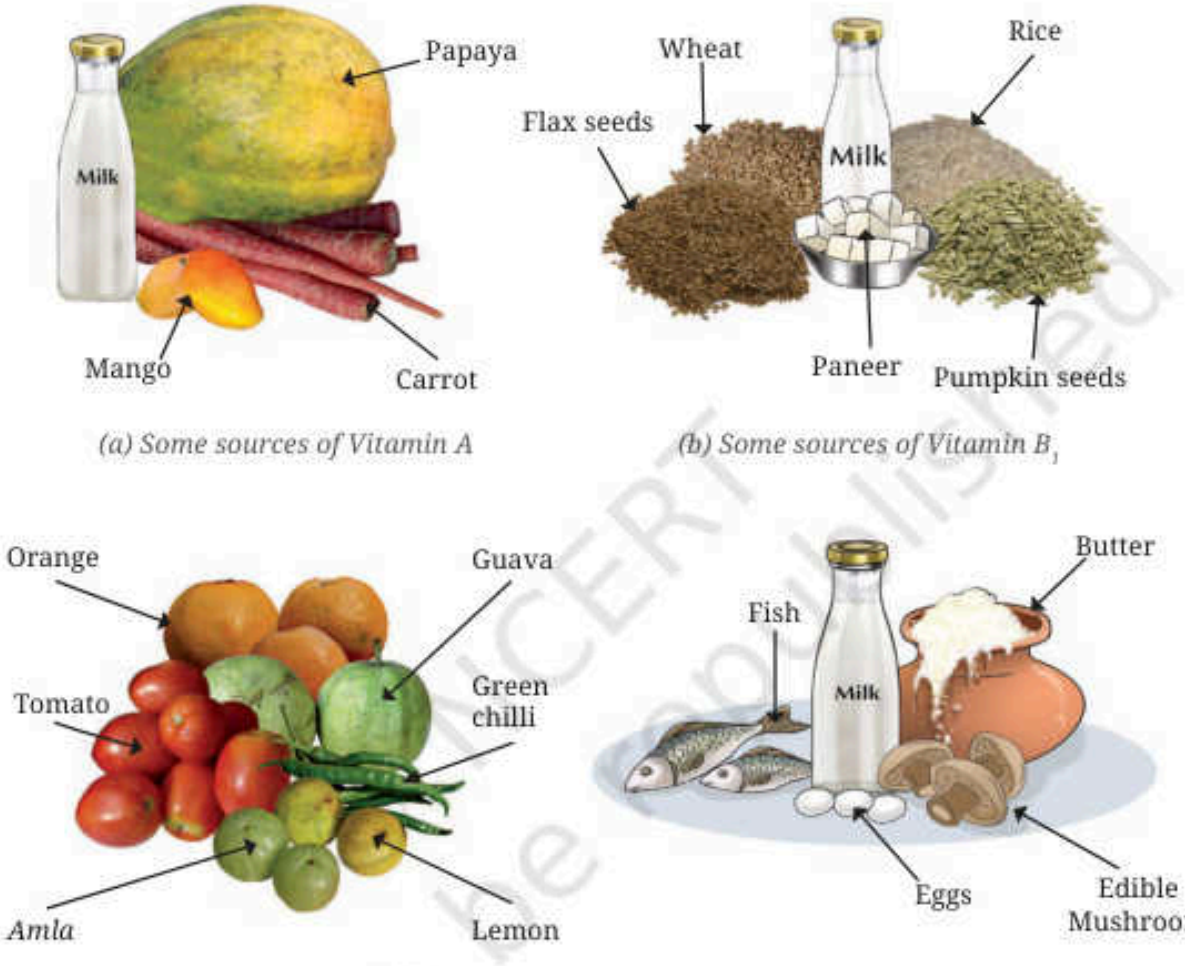
© NCERT not to be republished

Food component (Vitamin/ Mineral)	Functions	Some sources	Deficiency disease/ disorder	Symptoms
Vitamin A	Keeps eyes and skin healthy	Papaya, carrot, mango, milk	Loss of vision	Poor vision, loss of vision in darkness (night blindness), sometimes complete loss of vision
Vitamin B_1	Keeps heart healthy and supports body to perform various functions	Legumes, nuts, whole grains, seeds, milk products	Beriberi	Swelling, tingling or burning sensation in feet and hands, trouble in breathing
Vitamin C	Helps body to fight diseases	*Amla*, guava, green chilli, orange, lemon	Scurvy	Bleeding gums, slow healing of wounds
Vitamin D	Helps body absorb calcium for bone and teeth health	Exposure to sunlight, milk, butter, fish, eggs	Rickets	Soft and bent bones
Calcium	Keeps bones and teeth healthy	Milk/soya milk, curd, cheese, paneer	Bone and tooth decay	Weak bones, tooth decay
Iodine	Helps to perform physical and mental activities	Seaweed, water chestnut (*singhada*), iodised salt	Goitre	Swelling at the front of the neck
Iron	Important component of blood	Green leafy vegetables, beetroot, pomegranate	Anaemia	Weakness, shortness of breath

Fig. 3.5: Chart of vitamins and minerals, their functions, some sources, related deficiency disease(s)/disorder(s) and symptoms

© NCERT not to be republished

From Fig. 3.5, you have learnt that **vitamins** (A, B_1, C and D) and **minerals** (calcium, iodine, and iron) are two groups of food components that protect our body from various diseases. But, how can we overcome vitamin and mineral **deficiency diseases** or disorders?



(a) Some sources of Vitamin A

(b) Some sources of Vitamin B_1

(c) Some sources of Vitamin C

(d) Some sources of Vitamin D

Fig. 3.6: Some sources of different vitamins

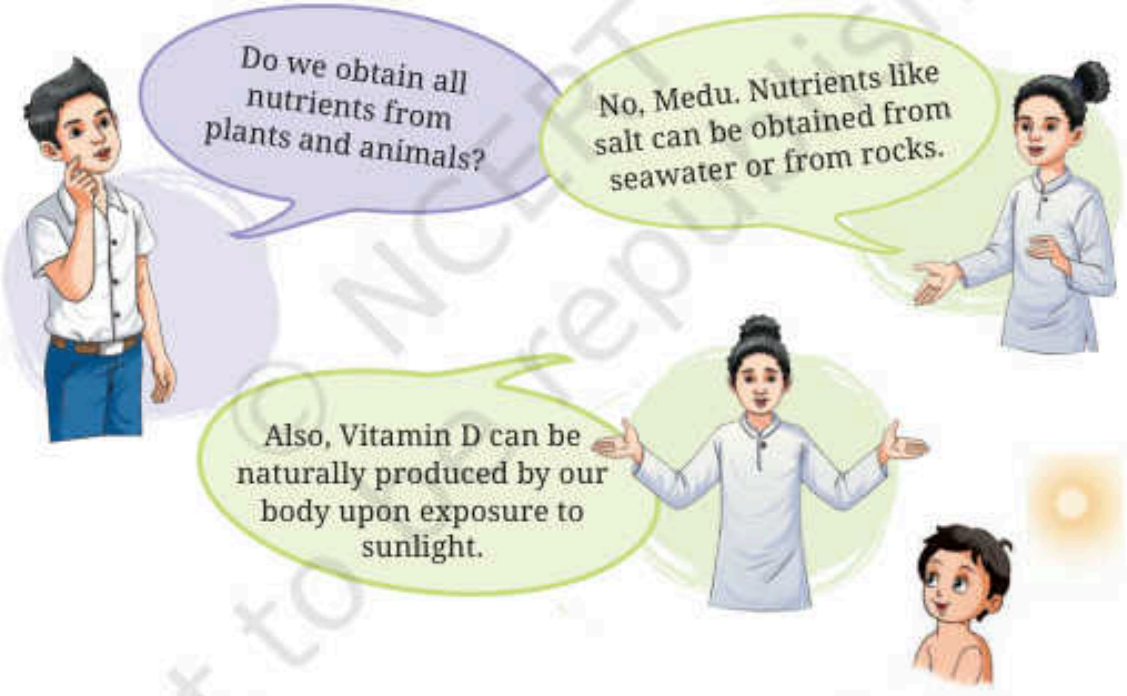
Food components that provide energy, support growth, help repair and protect our body from diseases, and maintain various bodily functions are called **nutrients**. The major nutrients in our food include carbohydrates, proteins, fats, vitamins and minerals.

Vitamins and minerals are also called **protective nutrients.** These nutrients protect our body from diseases and keep us healthy. Your parents may have advised you to have

© NCERT not to be republished

milk, green vegetables, fruits and wholegrains regularly. These food items are some sources of vitamins (Fig. 3.6) and minerals. Although vitamins and minerals are required in small amounts, they are essential to keep our body healthy.

What differences do you **observe** in raw and cooked vegetables? Have you ever noticed that vegetables sometimes lose their bright colour, or become softer and less crisp when cooked? Some nutrients like vitamin C and others are lost during cooking due to high heat. Would it not be wise to include fruits and uncooked vegetables into our diet? Washing cut or peeled vegetables and fruits may also result in the loss of some vitamins. However, it is highly recommended that all fruits and vegetables be thoroughly washed before consumption.



Fruits and vegetables are rich in dietary fibres. Let us see how dietary fibres are beneficial for us.

In addition to the essential nutrients, our body needs dietary fibres and water. Dietary fibres, also known as **roughage**, do not provide any nutrients to our body. However, they are an essential component of our food. They help our body get rid of undigested food and ensure smooth passage of stools. Roughage in our food is provided mainly by suitable plant products.

© NCERT not to be republished

Green leafy vegetables, fresh fruits, wholegrains, pulses and nuts are good sources of roughage.

Eating food that is locally grown and plant based, to the extent possible, is not only healthy for the body but is also good for our environment and our planet.



Water is also an essential part of our diet. It helps the body absorb nutrients from food. It removes waste from the body through sweat and urine. We should drink sufficient water regularly to keep ourselves healthy.

What are the food sources that provide water to our body? List a few of them. ?

Know a scientist



Coluthur Gopalan (1918–2019) initiated nutrition research in India. He analysed more than 500 Indian foods for their nutritional value and recommended an appropriate diet in the Indian context. He led surveys on the nutritional status of the Indian population, identifying widespread deficiencies in protein, energy, and other food components. This led to the implementation of the Mid Day Meal Programme in 2002, now a 'PM POSHAN' initiative, to provide balanced food in the government-run and government-aided schools of our country. This scheme has played a role in improving the health and nutrition of millions of children nationwide.

© NCERT not to be republished

Table 3.3: Exploring nutrients present in various food items

Name of the food item	Colour of the food item for starch test		Oily patch for fat test		Colour of the food item for protein test		Starch present (Yes/ No)	Fat present (Yes/ No)	Protein present (Yes/ No)
	Before iodine test	After iodine test	Predic-tion (Yes/No)	Observa-tion (Yes/No)	Before protein test	After protein test			
Potato									
Cucumber									
Boiled rice									
Boiled gram									
Peanuts									
Bread/ Chapati									
Butter									
Coconut									
Any other									

3.4 Balanced Diet

Are nutritional requirements the same for everyone? Do you and your grandparents need the same type or the same amount of nutrients? Requirements of the type and amount of nutrients in a diet may vary according to age, gender, physical activity, health status, lifestyle, and so on.

Activity 3.8: Let us find out

You have listed food consumed by you during the week in Activity 3.1. Check whether your food contains all the nutrients and other essential components necessary for growth and development. If not, check which nutrients or other food components need to be added.

A diet that has all essential nutrients, roughage, and water in the right amount for proper growth and development of the body is known as a **balanced diet**. What changes would you make in your diet to make it a balanced diet?

© NCERT not to be republished

Reprint 2026-27

Activity 3.9: Let us compare

Read the nutritional information given below for a packet of potato wafers and a packet of roasted *chana* shown here.



(a) Potato wafers



(b) Roasted chana

Nutritional Information (per 100 g)	
Energy	536 kcal (kilocalories)
Fats	35.0 g
Carbohydrates	53.0 g
Proteins	7.0 g
Dietary Fibre	4.8 g

Nutritional Information (per 100 g)	
Energy	355 kcal (kilocalories)
Fats	6.26 g
Carbohydrates	58.58 g
Proteins	18.64 g
Dietary Fibre	16.8 g

Based on the nutritional information on the food packets given above, which food would you choose? Why?

Some foods have high calories due to high sugar and fat content. Moreover, they contain very low amounts of proteins, minerals, vitamins, and dietary fibres. These foods are called junk foods. These foods include potato wafers, candy bars and carbonated drinks. Consuming these foods frequently is not good as these are not healthy for our body. They make a person obese. Such a person may suffer from several health problems. You should always remember Dr Poshita's statement that 'Health is the Ultimate Wealth.' We should take care of our body to stay healthy. Eating a balanced diet and avoiding junk food contribute towards

© NCERT not to be republished

PREFACE

The Fiscal Responsibility and Budget Management Act, 2003, was enacted to, among other things, provide for the responsibility of the Central Government to ensure inter-generational equity in fiscal management and long-term macroeconomic stability. The Fiscal Responsibility and Budget Management Act, 2003 and the Fiscal Responsibility and Budget Management Rules, 2004 made under Section 8 of the Act came into force from 5th July 2004.

The FRBM framework mandates the Central Government to limit the Fiscal Deficit upto three per cent of Gross Domestic Product by 31st March, 2021. It further provides that the Central Government shall endeavour to limit the General Government Debt to 60 per cent of GDP and the Central Government Debt to 40 per cent of GDP, by 31st March, 2025.

In RE 2025-26, the Government has retained its Fiscal Deficit target at 4.4 per cent of GDP. Further, in line with the commitment made in the Budget Speech for FY 2021-22 and the fiscal consolidation path presented in Budget of FY 2025-26, the fiscal deficit to GDP in the FY 2026-27 is projected at 4.3 per cent.

This document contains the Macroeconomic Framework Statement and Medium-term Fiscal Policy cum Fiscal Policy Strategy Statement. They provide an assessment of the growth prospects of the economy and strategies of the Government in the forthcoming financial year relating to taxation, expenditure, market borrowings and other liabilities. A Statement of deviation explaining the reasons for deviation from the fiscal targets mentioned in Section 4 and compliance obligations under Section 7(3)(b) of the FRBM Act, 2003, on the Central Government, has also been included. The FRBM policy statements are hereby laid before both the Houses of the Parliament.

2. MEDIUM TERM FISCAL POLICY CUM FISCAL POLICY STRATEGY STATEMENT

1. Union Budget 2026-27 has as its fiscal anchor the debt glide path indicated in Budget 2025-26 and Budget 2024-25 (regular) and is being presented against the backdrop of ongoing fiscal consolidation announced in FY 2021-22, which has provided a good foundation for making available the resources required to balance the development priorities without compromising on fiscal prudence. As announced in Budget 2021-22, the Government made true its intention of reaching a fiscal deficit below 4.5 per cent of GDP in FY 2025-26. Going ahead, it would be the endeavour of the Government to adopt a fiscal stance that would put the Central Government debt on a declining path.

2. Major fiscal indicators of the Union Government in the Revised Estimates (RE) of FY 2025-26 and the Budget Estimates (BE) of FY 2026-27 as a per cent of GDP, are summarized in the table below.

Fiscal Indicators - Rolling Targets as a Percentage of GDP

	Revised Estimates	Budget Estimates
	2025-26	2026-27
1. Fiscal Deficit	4.4	4.3
2. Revenue Deficit	1.5	1.5
3. Primary Deficit	0.8	0.7
4. Tax Revenue (Gross)	11.4	11.2
5. Non-tax Revenue	1.9	1.7
6. Central Government Debt	56.1	55.6

Notes:

1. *"GDP" is the Gross Domestic Product at Current Market Price.*
2. *Central Government Debt includes external public debt valued at current exchange rates, total outstanding liabilities on Public Account including investment in Special Securities of States under NSSF and EBR liabilities, etc.*
3. *Liabilities on account of investment in Special Securities of States, under NSSF are 0.7 per cent and 0.5 per cent of GDP in RE 2025-26 and BE 2026-27, respectively. The Central Government Debt net of these liabilities stands at 55.5 per cent and 55.1 per cent of GDP in RE 2025-26 and BE 2026-27, respectively.*

3. The process of fiscal consolidation since 2021-22 has resulted in improvement in fiscal deficit from 6.7 per cent of GDP in 2021-22 to 4.4 per cent of GDP in 2025-26 RE. This improvement is due to sustained efforts to maintain revenue receipts on the budgeted path and the rationalization of expenditure, without losing focus on economic growth. Continuation of the policy measures already implemented in the domain of taxation and expenditure management as presented under the fiscal policy strategy of this statement form the basis of projections.

4. However, uncertainty associated with significant changes in global macroeconomic and geopolitical environment continue to be concerns in fiscal policy management. While India's growth outlook remains positive, as mentioned in the Macroeconomic Framework Statement, it is not insulated from the risks emanating from outside the country. In this context, rolling targets for next two years have not been provided. A Statement explaining the reasons for deviation from the fiscal commitments / obligations mentioned in Section 4 and compliance obligations under Section 7(3)(b) of the FRBM Act, 2003, is provided at the end of this Statement.

Fiscal Policy Strategy for FY 2025-26

5. The Central Government's total expenditure during April – December 2025 was ₹33.81 lakh crore.

Within the total expenditure, capital expenditure stood at ₹7.88 lakh crore. Effective capital expenditure (defined as capital expenditure plus Grant-in-Aid for creation of capital assets) was ₹9.66 lakh crore.

6. Receipts of the Central Government during April-December 2025 are as follows. Gross Tax Revenue (GTR), at ₹29.84 lakh crore, recorded YoY growth of about 8.5 per cent in the first nine months of FY 2025-26 over the same period in the FY 2024-25. Revenue Receipts [Tax (net to Centre) plus Non-Tax Revenue] of the Centre were at ₹24.79 lakh crore. This was about 72.5 per cent of Budget Estimates of FY 2025-26.

7. During the nine months of FY 2025-26, Direct and Indirect tax receipts were ₹17.46 lakh crore and ₹12.38 lakh crore, respectively. These represent a YoY growth of around 7.9 per cent and 9.4 per cent in Direct tax and Indirect tax respectively.

8. Non-Tax Revenues (NTR) of the Union Government in the first nine months of FY 2025-26 were ₹5.40 lakh crore. This accounts for 92.6 per cent of BE of FY 2025-26 and much higher than the five years' moving average of 80.9 per cent of BE.

9. Fiscal Deficit at the end of December 2025, is estimated at ₹8.56 lakh crore (or 54.5 per cent of the Budget Estimate of FY 2025-26). Fiscal Assessment vis-à-vis mid-year benchmarks, as required under Rule 7 of FRBM Rules, 2004, has been carried out for H1 of FY 2025-26. There is no deviation in the three mid-year benchmarks prescribed under the FRBM Rules.

10. Given the above, the total expenditure in Revised Estimates (RE) 2025-26 is estimated at ₹49.65 lakh crore. This translates into a growth of 6.7 per cent over actuals of FY 2024-25. The Revenue Expenditure and Capital Expenditure are estimated at ₹38.69 lakh crore and ₹10.96 lakh crore, respectively, in RE 2025-26. The revenue receipts and non-debt capital receipts of the Central Government are projected at ₹33.42 lakh crore and ₹0.64 lakh crore, respectively.

11. Fiscal Deficit in RE 2025-26 is estimated at 4.4 per cent of GDP, at the same level as BE 2025-26. The Revenue Deficit and Primary Deficit are projected at 1.5 and 0.8 per cent of GDP, respectively, in RE 2025-26.

12. The projected fiscal deficit of ₹15.58 lakh crore in RE 2025-26 is planned to be financed through various means including market borrowing, NSSF, etc. The Gross and Net borrowings through dated securities (G-Sec) were planned at ₹14.82 lakh crore and ₹11.54 lakh crore in BE 2025-26, respectively. Up to January 27, 2026, the Government has completed Gross and Net borrowings of ₹12.75 lakh crore and ₹7.87 lakh crore, respectively, without any disruption with a weightage average yield of about 6.65 per cent and weightage average maturity of about 19.03 years.

13. Central Government debt, based on FRBM definition, is estimated to be at 56.1 per cent of GDP in RE 2025-26. It also includes the liabilities on account of investment in Special Securities of the States, under the NSSF, which are expected to be 0.7 per cent of GDP in RE 2025-26. The Central Government debt net of these liabilities is about 55.5 per cent of GDP in RE 2025-26.

14. Section 4(1)(c) of the FRBM Act places a ceiling of 0.5 per cent of GDP for assuming incremental guarantees with respect to any loan on security of the Consolidated Fund of India in a financial year. During FY 2024- 25, net accretion to the stock of guarantees was ₹43,628.39 crore (or 0.13 per cent of GDP). This is well within the limit of 0.5 per cent set under the FRBM Act. The Guarantees outstanding, given by the Union Government, were about ₹3.33 lakh crore at the end of FY 2024-25. As a percent of GDP, these have declined from 3.3 per cent in FY 2004-05 to 1.0 per cent by end of FY 2024-25. A disclosure statement on outstanding guarantees is part of the disclosure statements mandated under Rule 6 of FRBM Rules, 2004. This has been included in Statement 1(iii) of Receipt Budget, 2026-27.

Fiscal Outlook for FY 2026-27

15. In the Budget for FY 2026-27, nominal GDP is projected to grow by 10.0 per cent over the First Advance Estimates of FY 2025-26.

16. The Fiscal Deficit in BE 2026-27 is projected to be ₹16.96 lakh crore. This translates into a fiscal deficit to GDP ratio of 4.3 per cent in FY 2026-27 as against 4.4 per cent in RE 2025-26. Similarly, the Revenue Deficit is estimated at 1.5 per cent of GDP in BE 2026-27 at the same level compared to RE 2025-26.

Revenue Receipts (Tax and Non-tax)

17. In BE 2026-27, Gross Tax Revenue (GTR) is estimated at ₹44.04 lakh crore. It represents a growth of 8.0 per cent over RE 2025-26. Direct Taxes at ₹26.97 lakh crore are the major contributor to GTR (61.2 per cent of the GTR). Indirect taxes are estimated at ₹17.07 lakh crore.

18. In BE 2026-27, the GTR to GDP ratio is estimated at 11.2 per cent. The Budget 2026-27 is also the first year of the award period of Sixteenth Finance Commission (SFC). SFC has recommended for retaining the share of devolution to the States at 41 per cent of divisible pool. The Tax Revenues (Net to Centre) are projected to be ₹28.67 lakh crore.

19. In BE 2026-27, NTR of the Central Government is projected at ₹6.66 lakh crore. Revenue Receipts of the Union Government [comprising Tax Revenues (Net to Centre) and Non-Tax Revenues (NTR)], are estimated at ₹35.33 lakh crore. Revenue Receipt estimates assume a growth of 5.7 per cent over RE 2025-26.

Non-Debt Capital Receipts

20. In BE 2026-27, the Non-Debt Capital Receipts (comprising Recovery of Loans & Advances and Other Miscellaneous Capital Receipts) are estimated at ₹1.18 lakh crore. However, the actual realisation of Other Miscellaneous Capital Receipts depends on the prevailing market conditions during the course of the year.

Expenditure

21. The total expenditure of the Central Government in BE 2026-27 is projected to be ₹53.47 lakh crore (13.6 per cent of GDP) showing a growth of 7.7 per cent over RE 2025-26 of ₹49.65 lakh crore.

Capital Expenditure

22. The Budget for FY 2026-27 projects ₹12.22 lakh crore (3.1 per cent of GDP) towards capital expenditure. This includes capital support to States through SASCI (Special Assistance as Loan to States for Capital Expenditure) with an outlay of ₹2.0 lakh crore.

Effective Capital Expenditure

23. Effective Capital Expenditure of the Union Government includes GoI's capital expenditure and Grants-in-aid for creation of capital assets. Together, they constitute investments that enhance and upgrade productive capacity of the economy.

24. In BE 2026-27, the allocation under Grants-in-aid for creation of capital assets is projected at ₹4.93 lakh crore (or 1.3 per cent of GDP). Thus, the effective capital expenditure in FY 2026-27 is estimated at ₹17.15 lakh crore (or 4.4 per cent of GDP).

Revenue Expenditure

25. The Revenue Expenditure for BE 2026-27 has been projected to be ₹41.25 lakh crore or 10.5 per cent of GDP in BE 2026-27, compared to 10.8 per cent in RE 2025-26. Select items under the revenue expenditure head are discussed briefly in the following paragraphs.

(i) Interest Payments

26. In BE 2026-27, the Interest payments are estimated at ₹14.04 lakh crore against ₹12.76 lakh crore in BE 2025-26. The estimates of interest payment depend on the prevailing domestic and international interest rates.

(ii) Major Subsidies

27. Major subsidies which include food (₹2.28 lakh crore), fertiliser (₹1.71 lakh crore), and petroleum (₹0.12 lakh crore) are estimated at ₹4.11 lakh crore in BE 2026-27. Major subsidies at 1.0 per cent of GDP form roughly 10.0 per cent of Revenue Expenditure in BE 2026-27.

(iii) Pensions

28. The Pension commitment of the Union Government (for both civilian and defence together) is estimated at ₹2.96 lakh crore in BE 2026-27 (or 0.8 per cent of GDP) compared to ₹2.87 lakh crore in RE 2025-26 (0.8 per cent of GDP). The Pension payments are spread across the four Government of India Demands for Grants viz, Defence (Pensions), Civil (Pensions), Telecommunications and Department of Health & Family Welfare.

(iv) Tax devolution to the States

29. Based on recommendations of the Finance Commission (FC), the Union Government devolves taxes to States during the FC cycle. As mentioned previously, SFC recommended to retain States' share at 41 per cent in the divisible pool, and this recommendation is accepted by the Government. In BE 2026-27, tax devolution to the States is estimated

at ₹15.26 lakh crore compared to ₹13.93 lakh crore in RE 2025-26 which includes an additional amount of ₹9,084.02 crore on account of dues receivable by the Union Government from States under devolution from the previous years. Tax devolution to the States in BE 2026-27 is 3.9 per cent of GDP and ₹1.33 lakh crore more than tax devolution of RE 2025-26 (including past arrears).

(v) Finance Commission Grants

30. In BE 2026-27, the Finance Commission grants are estimated at ₹1.29 lakh crore. Grants for Urban and Rural Local Bodies are estimated at ₹0.45 lakh crore and ₹0.56 lakh crore, respectively. The grants for financing disaster management are estimated at ₹0.28 lakh crore. Thus, total resources shared, tax devolution and FC Grants, with States through the Finance Commission route are estimated at ₹16.56 lakh crore in BE 2026-27.

Borrowings- Public debt and other liabilities

31. The Union Government finances its fiscal deficit through borrowings. These are in the form of dated securities (G-Sec), NSSF, external assistance, etc. In BE 2026-27, the Central Government has estimated the gross and net borrowings through dated securities (G-Sec) at ₹17.20 lakh crore (or 4.4 per cent of GDP) and ₹11.73 lakh crore (or 3.0 per cent of GDP), respectively. In RE 2025-26, the gross and net borrowings are projected at ₹14.61 lakh crore and ₹10.40 lakh crore respectively.

32. Other sources of financing the Fiscal Deficit are NSSF investments in Special securities of the Central Government, net external assistance and the Public Account balances, etc. For financing the Fiscal Deficit in BE 2026-27, borrowing from NSSF is estimated at about ₹3.87 lakh crore; whereas those from external sources and State Provident Funds are estimated at ₹15,385 crore and ₹3,500 crore (on net basis), respectively.

33. In accordance with the definition of 'Central Government debt' as defined in the FRBM Act, Central Government debt is estimated at 55.6 per cent of GDP in BE 2026-27 (which is lower than 56.1 per cent of GDP in RE 2025-26). The liabilities of the Central Government are mostly domestic in nature with a small portion (3.3 per cent of total liabilities at book value) sourced from external sector. Also, within the external sector, most of liabilities have been contracted through multilateral agencies.

34. A portion of outstanding liabilities on Public Account of India is on account of NSSF investment in the State Government special securities (which are *de facto* liabilities of the State Governments) and would be repaid by the States at the time of maturity. If such investments are excluded, the adjusted Central Government debt is estimated at 55.1 per cent of GDP at the end of FY 2026-27.

Assessment of sustainability relating to

(i) The balance between Revenue receipts and Revenue expenditure

35. In BE 2026-27, the revenue expenditure and revenue receipts of the Union Government are estimated at ₹41.25 lakh crore (10.5 per cent of GDP) and ₹35.33 lakh crore (9.0 per cent of GDP), respectively. The gap between the revenue expenditure and receipts is the Revenue Deficit, which is estimated at 1.5 per cent of GDP in BE 2026-27. The ratio of revenue receipts to revenue expenditure is projected at 85.6 per cent in BE 2026-27. Further, if adjustments on account of Grants-in-aid for creation of capital assets is considered – since these are capital in nature but accounted for as revenue expenditure of the Centre, the ratio of revenue receipts to revenue expenditure is about 97.3 per cent in BE 2026-27.

(ii) The use of capital receipts including market borrowings for generating productive assets

36. Ratio of Capital Expenditure to Fiscal Deficit measures the extent to which borrowed resources are used for financing the capital expenditure or asset creation of the Government. In BE 2026-27, this ratio is estimated at 72.1 per cent which higher than 70.3 per cent in RE 2025-26 and 66.8 per cent in FY 2024-25. Further, the ratio of Effective Capital Expenditure to Fiscal Deficit is estimated at 101.1 per cent in BE 2026-27 as compared to 90.1 and 84.1 per cent in RE 2025-26 and FY 2024-25, respectively. This indicates progressive improvement in the quality of public expenditure over the years.

Fiscal Policy Strategy for 2026-27

37. The fiscal policy strategy for FY 2026-27 will continue to be guided by the debt glide path indicated in the Budget 2025-26. The medium-term aim to reach a debt to GDP ratio of 50±1 per cent by FY 2030-31, with the fiscal deficit acting as the

operational target. In line with the above targets, it is estimated that Central Government debt to GDP ratio will be 55.6 per cent of GDP in BE 2026-27 with Fiscal Deficit target of 4.3 per cent of GDP.

38. Other aspects of the fiscal strategy include support to economic growth through continued focus on capital expenditure, leaving adequate fiscal room to respond to global economic events and to ensure continued prosperity of the country in its journey towards Viksit Bharat.

Tax Policy

39. Any reform is a dynamic and ongoing process, and in this endeavor, several measures have been undertaken in the domain of direct taxes – both legislative and administrative. In addition, technological innovations have been at the forefront of direct tax administration to make it transparent and responsive, while reducing the compliance burden and strengthening the information networks to augment revenue.

40. Some important reform measures, initiated under direct taxes in recent years include the following:

a) The new simplified Income-tax Act, 2025 has been enacted by the Parliament which shall come into effect on 01.04.2026. The Act is a simplified version of the erstwhile Income-tax Act, 1961, making it concise, lucid, easy to read and understand. The simplification exercise was guided by three core principles of textual and structural simplification for improved clarity and coherence, no major tax policy changes to ensure continuity and certainty, and no modifications in tax rates, preserving predictability for taxpayers.

b) Finance Act, 2025 provided substantial relief under the new tax regime with new slabs and tax rates.

c) The period of holding of capital assets has been simplified with amended provisions, providing for a period of 12/24 months as holding period for capital assets.

d) To provide a level playing field between new manufacturing co-operative societies and new manufacturing companies, a new section 115BAE was introduced *vide* Finance Act, 2023 to provide concessional tax regime to such co-operative societies.

e) Measures have been undertaken to relax the norms for prosecution such as decriminalisation of Section 276A, substantial increase in threshold for launching prosecution. In line with the relaxation for prosecution in respect of TDS payments under 276B, prosecution in respect of TCS payments under section 276BB of the Act has also been decriminalised up to the due date of filing of quarterly TCS Statements.

f) Equalisation Levy at the rate of 2 per cent of consideration received for e-commerce supply of goods or services has been removed w.e.f 1st August, 2024. Further, equalisation levy at the rate of 6% of consideration for specified services has been removed from 1st April, 2025.

g) Amendments have been made in the Act to extend tax benefits to subscribers of Unified Pension Scheme, incentivize start-ups by extending eligibility of tax benefits to those incorporated before 01.04.2030, extension of tax benefits to specified persons under section 10(23FE) till FY 2029-30 for making investments etc.

h) PAN is being leveraged to become Business Identification Number (BIN) for providing registration to a number of government departments and services.

i) An Integrated e-Filing and Centralised Processing Center 2.0 (CPC 2.0) project was launched with a view to providing better e-filing experience, ease of compliance, more accurate and faster processing of ITRs.

41. In Indirect taxes, several measures to augment receipts under Goods and Services Tax (GST) have been taken. These, *inter-alia*, include:

a) Union Government on the recommendation of GST Council has undertaken a comprehensive rate rationalisation and structural simplification of 4-tiered tax rate structure into a citizen-friendly 'Simple Tax' - a 2-rate structure with a standard rate of 18% and a merit rate of 5%, a special de-merit rate of 40% for a select few goods and services. This will simplify the present tax structure and boost domestic consumption.

b) The Union Government has notified an optimal simplified GST registration scheme wherein registration shall be granted on

an automated basis within three working days from the date of application in case of low-risk applicants and applicants for which output tax liability on supplies to registered person will not exceed ₹ 2.5 lakh per month. This measure will reduce the compliance friction in respect of the registration of the taxpayers.

c) The GST regime is progressively stabilising as is seen from the widening and deepening of tax base. In BE 2026-27, CGST receipts are estimated at ₹10.19 lakh crore, registering a growth of 6.3 per cent over RE 2025-26.

d) Customs duty rates have been rationalised in Budget 2025 with the intent to promote domestic value addition while also balancing the concerns of the domestic industry. Review of custom duty exemptions, review of customs duty rates, addressing issues of misclassification are an ongoing exercise and undertaken on continuous basis in consultation with the stakeholders including administrative ministries and trade associations.

e) As a measure of trade facilitation in customs, 31 separate customs duty notifications were merged into a single and comprehensive notification. This consolidation will streamline ease of compliance in customs procedure by offering one reference point and make regulations easier for interpretation and application. This initiative is in sync with the broader agenda of Government for fostering a transparent and business friendly environment and promotes ease of doing business.

f) Other measures taken for facilitation of trade and streamlining compliance measures are sanction of risk-based provisional refund to facilitate refund claims on account of zero-rated supply of goods or services or both, amendment in CGST Act to provide for GST refunds in respect of low value export consignments, simplified GST registration scheme for small and low-risk businesses, encouraging women participation in international trade, enhancing gender inclusivity in logistics etc.

Expenditure Policy

42. The Union Government continues to leverage technology as a significant tool for public financial management. The Treasury Single Account (TSA), Single Nodal Agency (SNA) and Central Nodal Agency (CNA) guidelines have ensured transparency and helped in better cash management.

43. SNA SPARSH (Single Nodal Agency - System for Payments and Reporting Across Sectors Holistically) aims at enabling "Just-in-time" fund flow from the Consolidated Fund of India and Consolidated Funds of States. Pilot rollout had been notified and, as of now, 50 Centrally Sponsored Schemes across States/UTs have been onboarded.

44. The scope of Direct Benefit Transfer (DBT) has been expanding with adoption of new programs and technologies under Digital India Program. It is aimed to achieve (i) "Just in time" transfer of funds and (ii) complete tracking of realization of funds from its release to its credit into the bank account of intended beneficiaries. Reforms in expenditure management makes a direct and significant contribution to the Digital India Initiative of Government of India by enabling electronic payment and receipt for Ministries/ Departments in Government of India.

Government Borrowings, Lending and Investments

45. Union Government's debt management strategy stands on three pillars – reduction in borrowing costs, risk mitigation and market development.

46. In BE 2026-27, Gross and Net Market borrowings by the Government of India (GoI) through dated securities are budgeted at ₹17.20 lakh crore and ₹11.73 lakh crore, respectively, compared to ₹14.82 lakh crore and ₹11.54 lakh crore in BE 2025-26.

47. As on January 27, 2026, gross market borrowings through dated securities during FY 2025-26 stands at 86.0% (₹12.75 lakh crore) as against BE 2025-26. Further, as on January 27, 2026, net market borrowings through dated securities during FY 2025-26 stands at 68.2 percent (₹7.87 lakh crore) as against BE 2025-26. Notwithstanding the impact of global financial conditions on the Indian G-sec market, the market borrowing programme in FY 2025-26 has been conducted in a non-disruptive manner.

48. Further, to improve debt maturity profile and to better manage redemption pressures, an active

debt management strategy through switching of securities has been adopted. Switching of securities of about ₹1.64 lakh crore has been completed till date. These measures have helped improve the Union Government's risk profile. Also, rollover risks in the Government debt portfolio is low. The Weighted Average Maturity (WAM) of primary issuances of dated securities in FY 2025-26 (up to January 27, 2026) stands at 19.03 years vis-à-vis 20.65 years in FY 2024-25 and 18.09 years in FY 2023-24. Similarly, the Weighted Average Yield (WAY) of primary issuance of dated securities in FY 2025-26 (up to January 27, 2026) moderated to 6.65 percent from 6.96 per cent in FY 2024-25. As on January 27, 2026, net issuance of T-Bills stands at ₹(-)0.49 lakh crore, which has helped in reduction in short-term liabilities.

49. The Union Government actively opted for buyback of dated securities (G-Sec) as part of its debt management strategy. During FY 2025-26, buy-back operations of dated securities maturing in FY 2026-27 amounting to ₹86,775 crore were conducted. This strategy has not only helped in saving interest costs but eased the liquidity conditions in the banking system apart from moderating the yields.

Strategic priorities for FY 2026-27

50. The fiscal strategy of the Union Government for FY 2026-27 has already been explained in detail in the foregoing paragraphs. It rests on the principle of continuing on the path of gradual fiscal consolidation while retaining operational flexibility. The strategic priorities for the FY 2026-27 are augmentation of resources through continuation of policy reforms introduced in tax domain in conjunction with reasonable rationalization of expenditure, prioritization of expenditure towards the key developmental sectors, enhancing the social and physical infrastructure of the country in an inclusive manner by supporting and strengthening the capital spending of States, improving public expenditure quality and management by leveraging technology and an active debt management strategy.

Conclusion and Policy Evaluation

Statement explaining the reasons for deviation from the fiscal targets mentioned in Section 4 and compliance obligations under Section 7(3)(b) of the Fiscal Responsibility and Budget Management (FRBM) Act, 2003.

51. Section 4(1)(a) of the Fiscal Responsibility and Budget Management (FRBM) Act, 2003 mandates the Central Government to take appropriate measures to limit the Fiscal Deficit to three per cent of Gross Domestic Product (GDP) by 31st March, 2021. In continuation to this, Section 4(1)(b)(ii) requires that the Central Government shall endeavour to ensure that the Central Government debt does not exceed forty per cent of GDP by the end of FY 2024-25. Further, Section 4(1)(d) of the FRBM Act, 2003, also requires the Central Government to endeavour that the aforementioned fiscal targets are not exceeded after the stipulated dates. According to Section 7(3)(b)(i) of the FRBM Act, 2003, the Minister of Finance is required to make a statement in both Houses of Parliament explaining the deviation in meeting the obligations cast on the Central Government under this Act.

52. While the global growth is expected to be steady, the momentum is uneven and risks remain tilted to the downside. Global stability is based on a fragile balance of trade policy positions that are continuously shifting. Geopolitical flare-ups and possible escalation in tensions across continents could further upset this balance through supply chain and trade route disruptions, influencing investor sentiments.

53. As one of the fastest growing economies, the outlook for India remains positive, aided by strong growth momentum and active monetary policy strategy targeting inflation. Continued public investment, labour market reforms, human capital investments, tax reforms, digital transformation, and the formalisation of the economy are expected to drive the economy into a higher growth trajectory.

54. Against this backdrop, the Union Government would continue on its path of fiscal consolidation, while making all efforts to achieve inclusive, equitable and sustainable growth. The fiscal policy would be focused towards building strong macro-economic fundamentals that can withstand exogenous shocks and global uncertainties.

55. Starting FY 2026-27 till FY 2030-31, the Government would endeavour to keep fiscal deficit in each year such that the Central Government debt is on declining path.

*****

The Emergence of New Dynasties

By the seventh century, there were big landlords or warrior chiefs in different regions of the subcontinent. Existing kings often acknowledged them as their subordinates or *samantas*. They were expected to bring gifts for their kings or overlords, be present at their courts and provide them with military support. As *samantas* gained power and wealth, they declared themselves to be *maha-samanta*, *maha-mandaleshvara* (the great lord of a "circle" or region) and so on. Sometimes they asserted their independence from their overlords.



Fig. 1
Wall relief from Cave 15, Ellora, showing Vishnu as Narasimha, the man-lion. It is a work of the Rashtrakuta period.

One such instance was that of the Rashtrakutas in the Deccan. Initially they were subordinate to the Chalukyas of Karnataka. In the mid-eighth century, Dantidurga, a Rashtrakuta chief, overthrew his Chalukya overlord and performed a ritual called *hiranya-garbha* (literally, the golden womb). When this ritual was performed with the help of Brahmanas, it was thought to lead to the "rebirth" of the sacrificer as a Kshatriya, even if he was not one by birth.

In other cases, men from enterprising families used their military skills to carve out kingdoms. For instance, the Kadamba Mayurasharman and the Gurjara-Pratihara Harichandra were Brahmanas who gave up their traditional professions and took to arms, successfully establishing kingdoms in Karnataka and Rajasthan respectively.

Do you think being born as a Kshatriya was important in order to become a ruler during this period?

Administration in the Kingdoms

Many of these new kings adopted high-sounding titles such as *maharaja-adhiraja* (great king, overlord of kings), *tribhuvana-chakravartin* (lord of the three worlds) and so on. However, in spite of such claims,

Reprint 2024-25

they often shared power with their *samantas* as well as with associations of peasants, traders and Brahmanas.

In each of these states, resources were obtained from the producers – that is, peasants, cattle-keepers, artisans – who were often persuaded or compelled to surrender part of what they produced. Sometimes these were claimed as "rent" due to a lord who asserted that he owned the land. Revenue was also collected from traders.

Four hundred taxes!

The inscriptions of the Cholas who ruled in Tamil Nadu refer to more than 400 terms for different kinds of taxes. The most frequently mentioned tax is *vetti*, taken not in cash but in the form of forced labour, and *kadamai*, or land revenue. There were also taxes on thatching the house, the use of a ladder to climb palm trees, a cess on succession to family property, etc.

Are any such taxes collected today?

In what ways was this form of administration different from the present-day system?

These resources were used to finance the king's establishment, as well as for the construction of temples and forts. They were also used to fight wars, which were in turn expected to lead to the acquisition of wealth in the form of plunder, and access to land as well as trade routes.

The functionaries for collecting revenue were generally recruited from influential families, and positions were often hereditary. This was true about the army as well. In many cases, close relatives of the king held these positions.

Prashastis and Land Grants

Prashastis contain details that may not be literally true. But they tell us how rulers wanted to depict themselves – as valiant, victorious warriors, for example. These were composed by learned Brahmanas, who occasionally helped in the administration.

Reprint 2024-25

The "achievements" of Nagabhata

Many rulers described their achievements in *prashastis* (you read about the *prashasti* of the Gupta ruler Samudragupta last year).

One *prashasti*, written in Sanskrit and found in Gwalior, Madhya Pradesh, describes the exploits of Nagabhata, a Pratihara king, as follows:

The kings of Andhra, Saindhava (Sind), Vidarbha (part of Maharashtra) and Kalinga (part of Orissa) fell before him even as he was a prince …
He won a victory over Chakrayudha (the ruler of Kanauj)…
He defeated the king of Vanga (part of Bengal), Anarta (part of Gujarat), Malava (part of Madhya Pradesh), Kirata (forest peoples), Turushka (Turks), Vatsa, Matsya (both kingdoms in north India)…

Kings often rewarded Brahmanas by grants of land. These were recorded on copper plates, which were given to those who received the land.



Fig. 2
This is a set of copper plates recording a grant of land made by a ruler in the ninth century, written partly in Sanskrit and partly in Tamil. The ring holding the plates together is secured with the royal seal, to indicate that this is an authentic document.

Also, see if you can find some of the areas mentioned in the inscription on Map 1.
Other rulers made similar claims as well. Why do you think they made these claims?

Reprint 2024-25

What was given with the land

This is a part of the Tamil section of a land grant given by the Cholas:

We have demarcated the boundaries of the land by making earthen embankments, as well as by planting thorny bushes. This is what the land contains: fruit-bearing trees, water, land, gardens and orchards, trees, wells, open spaces, pasture-land, a village, anthills, platforms, canals, ditches, rivers, silt-laden land, tanks, granaries, fish ponds, bee hives, and deep lakes.

He who receives the land can collect taxes from it. He can collect the taxes imposed by judicial officers as fines, the tax on betel-leaves, that on woven cloth, as well as on vehicles. He can build large rooms, with upper stories made of baked bricks, he can get large and small wells dug, he can plant trees and thorny bushes, if necessary, he can get canals constructed for irrigation. He should ensure that water is not wasted, and that embankments are built.

? *List all the possible sources of irrigation mentioned in the inscription, and discuss how these might have been used.*

Unusual for the twelfth century was a long Sanskrit poem containing the history of kings who ruled over Kashmir. It was composed by an author named Kalhana. He used a variety of sources, including inscriptions, documents, eyewitness accounts and earlier histories, to write his account. Unlike the writers of *prashastis*, he was often critical about rulers and their policies.

Warfare for Wealth

You may have noticed that each of these ruling dynasties was based in a specific region. At the same time, they tried to control other areas. One particularly

Reprint 2024-25

prized area was the city of Kanauj in the Ganga valley. For centuries, rulers belonging to the Gurjara-Pratihara, Rashtrakuta and Pala dynasties fought for control over Kanauj. Because there were three "parties" in this long-drawn conflict, historians often describe it as the "tripartite struggle".

Rulers also tried to demonstrate their power and resources by building large temples. So, when they attacked one another's kingdoms, they often chose to target temples, which were sometimes extremely rich.

One such ruler is Mahmud of Ghazni, Afghanistan. He raided the subcontinent 17 times (1000–1025) with a religious motive. His targets were wealthy temples, including that of Somnath, Gujarat. Much of the wealth Mahmud carried away was used to create a splendid capital city at Ghazni.

Other kings who engaged in warfare included the Chahamanas, later known as the Chauhans, who ruled over the region around Delhi and Ajmer. They attempted to expand their control to the west and the east, where they were opposed by the Chalukyas of Gujarat and the Gahadavalas of western Uttar Pradesh. The Chahamana ruler was Prithviraja III (1168–1192), who defeated a Turk ruler named Sultan Muhammad Ghori in 1191, but lost to him the very next year, in 1192.



Look at Map 1 and suggest reasons why these rulers wanted to control Kanauj and the Ganga valley.



Look at Map 1 again and discuss why the Chahamanas may have wanted to expand their territories.

A Closer Look: The Cholas

From Uraiyur to Thanjavur

How did the Cholas rise to power? A minor chiefly family known as the Muttaraiyar held power in the Kaveri delta. They were subordinate to the Pallava kings of Kanchipuram. Vijayalaya, who belonged to the ancient chiefly family of the Cholas from Uraiyur, captured the delta from the Muttaraiyar in the middle of the ninth century. He built the town of Thanjavur and a temple for goddess Nishumbhasudini there.

© NCERT not to be republished

Reprint 2024-25



Map 2
The Chola kingdom and its neighbours.

The successors of Vijayalaya conquered neighbouring regions and the kingdom grew in size and power. The Pandyan and the Pallava territories to the south and north were made part of this kingdom. Rajaraja I, considered the most powerful Chola ruler, became king in 985 and expanded control over most of these areas. He also reorganised the administration of the empire. Rajaraja's son Rajendra I continued his policies and even invaded the Ganga valley, Sri Lanka and countries of Southeast Asia, developing a navy for these expeditions.

Splendid Temples and Bronze Sculpture

The big temples of Thanjavur and Gangaikonda-cholapuram, built by Rajaraja and Rajendra, are architectural and sculptural marvels.

© NCERT not to be republished

Reprint 2024-25



Fig. 3
The temple at Gangaikondacholapuram. Notice the way in which the roof tapers. Also look at the elaborate stone sculptures used to decorate the outer walls.

Chola temples often became the nuclei of settlements which grew around them. These were centres of craft production. Temples were also endowed with land by rulers as well as by others. The produce of this land went into maintaining all the specialists who worked at the temple and very often lived near it – priests, garland makers, cooks, sweepers, musicians, dancers, etc. In other words, temples were not only places of worship; they were the centres of economic, social and cultural life.

Amongst the crafts associated with temples, the making of bronze images was the most distinctive. Chola bronze images are considered amongst the finest in the world. While most images were of deities, sometimes images were made of devotees as well.

Reprint 2024-25

Agriculture and Irrigation

Many of the achievements of the Cholas were made possible through new developments in agriculture. Look at Map 2 again. Notice that the river Kaveri branches off into several small channels before emptying into the Bay of Bengal. These channels overflow frequently, depositing fertile soil on their banks. Water from the channels also provides the necessary moisture for agriculture, particularly the cultivation of rice.

Although agriculture had developed earlier in other parts of Tamil Nadu, it was only from the fifth or sixth century that this area was opened up for large-scale cultivation. Forests had to be cleared in some regions; land had to be levelled in other areas. In the delta region, embankments had to be built to prevent flooding and canals had to be constructed to carry water to the fields. In many areas, two crops were grown in a year.

In many cases it was necessary to water crops artificially. A variety of methods were used for irrigation. In some areas wells were dug. In other places huge tanks were constructed to collect rainwater. Remember that irrigation works require planning – organising

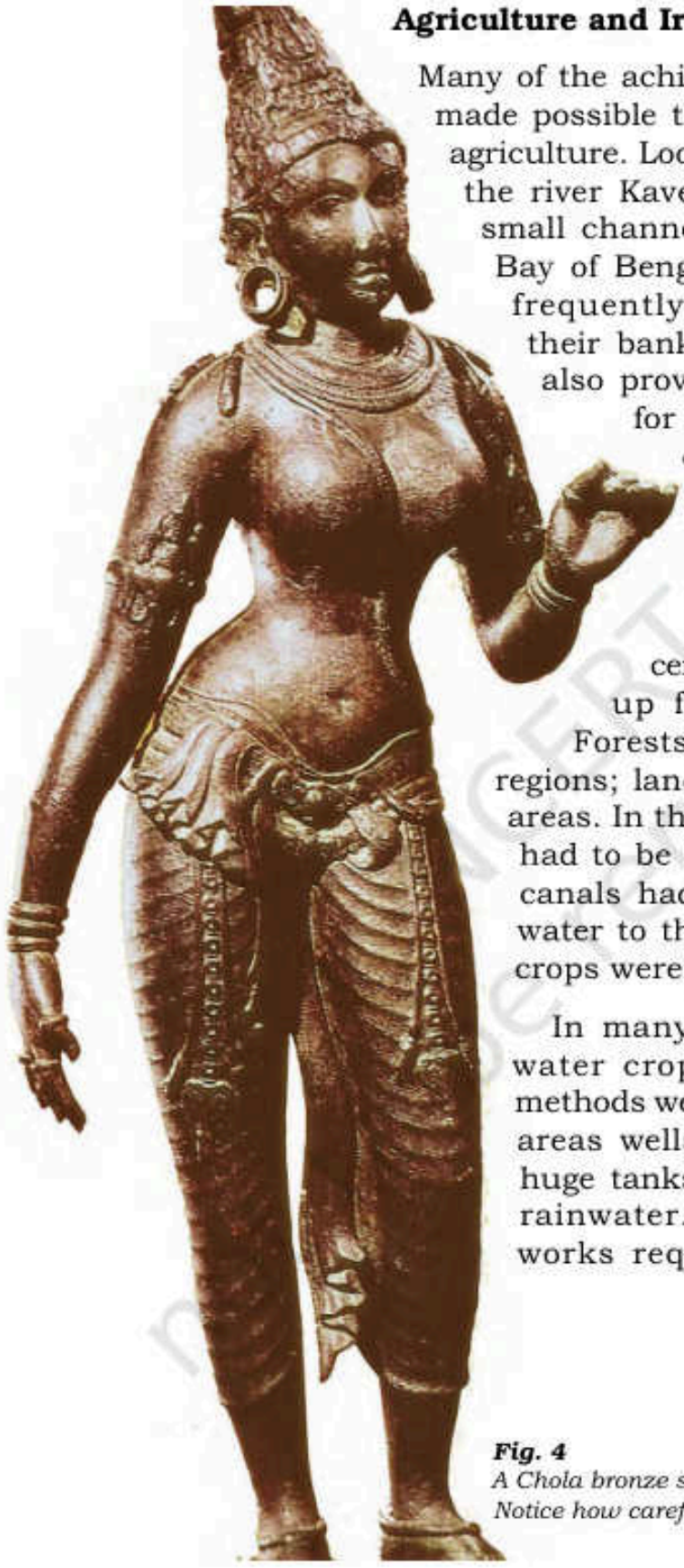


Fig. 4
A Chola bronze sculpture.
Notice how carefully it is decorated.

Reprint 2024-25



Fig. 5
A ninth-century sluice gate in Tamil Nadu. It regulated the outflow of water from a tank into the channels that irrigated the fields.
A sluice gate is traditionally a wood or metal barrier which is commonly used to control water levels and flow rates in rivers and canals.

labour and resources, maintaining these works and deciding on how water is to be shared. Most of the new rulers, as well as people living in villages, took an active interest in these activities.

The Administration of the Empire

How was the administration organised? Settlements of peasants, known as *ur*, became prosperous with the spread of irrigation agriculture. Groups of such villages formed larger units called *nadu*. The village council and the *nadu* performed several administrative functions including dispensing justice and collecting taxes.

Rich peasants exercised considerable control over the affairs of the *nadu* under the supervision of the central Chola government. The Chola kings gave some rich landowners titles like *muvendavelan* (a *velan* or peasant serving three kings), *araiyar* (chief), etc., as markers of respect, and entrusted them with important offices of the state at the centre.

Reprint 2024-25

Types of land

Chola inscriptions mention several categories of land:

vellanvagai
land of non-Brahmana peasant proprietors

brahmadeya
land gifted to Brahmanas

shalabhoga
land for the maintenance of a school

devadana, *tirunamattukkani*
land gifted to temples

pallichchhandam
land donated to Jaina institutions

We have seen that Brahmanas often received land grants or *brahmadeya*. As a result, a large number of Brahmana settlements emerged in the Kaveri valley as in other parts of south India.

Each *brahmadeya* was looked after by an assembly or *sabha* of prominent Brahmana landholders. These assemblies worked very efficiently. Their decisions were recorded in detail in inscriptions, often on the stone walls of temples. Associations of traders known as *nagarams* also occasionally performed administrative functions in towns.

Inscriptions from Uttaramerur in Chingleput district, Tamil Nadu, provide details of the way in which the *sabha* was organised. The *sabha* had separate committees to look after irrigation works, gardens, temples, etc. Names of those eligible to be members of these committees were written on small tickets of palm leaf; these tickets were put into an earthenware pot, from which a young boy was asked to take out the tickets, one by one for each committee.

© NCERT not to be republished

Reprint 2024-25

Inscriptions and texts

Who could be a member of a sabha? The Uttaramerur inscription lays down:

All those who wish to become members of the sabha should be owners of land from which land revenue is collected.
They should have their own homes.
They should be between 35 and 70 years of age.
They should have knowledge of the Vedas.
They should be well-versed in administrative matters and honest.
If anyone has been a member of any committee in the last three years, he cannot become a member of another committee.
Anyone who has not submitted his accounts, and those of his relatives, cannot contest the elections.

Do you think women participated in these assemblies? In your view are lotteries useful in choosing members of committees?

While inscriptions tell us about kings and powerful men, here is an excerpt from the *Periyapuranam*, a twelfth-century Tamil work, which informs us about the lives of ordinary men and women.

On the outskirts of Adanur was a small hamlet of Pulaiyas (a name used for a social group considered "outcastes" by Brahmanas and Vellalas), studded with small huts under old thatches and inhabited by agrarian labourers engaged in menial occupations. In the thresholds of the huts covered with strips of leather, little chickens moved about in groups; dark children who wore bracelets of black iron were prancing about, carrying little puppies … In the shade of the marudu (arjuna) trees, a female labourer put her baby to sleep on a sheet of leather; there were mango trees from whose branches drums were hanging; and under the coconut palms, in little hollows on the ground, tiny-headed bitches lay after whelping. The red-crested cocks crowed before dawn calling the brawny Pulaiyar (plural) to their day's work; and by day, under the shade of the kanji tree spread the voice of the wavy-haired Pulaiya women singing as they were husking paddy …

Were there any Brahmanas in this hamlet?
Describe all the activities that were taking place in the village.
Why do you think temple inscriptions ignore these activities?

Reprint 2024-25



3 DELHI: 12th TO 15th CENTURY

In Chapter 2 we saw that regions like the Kaveri delta became the centre of large kingdoms. Did you notice that there was no mention of a kingdom with Delhi as its capital? That was because Delhi became an important city only in the twelfth century.

Take a look at Table 1. Delhi first became the capital of a kingdom under the Tomara Rajputs, who were defeated in the middle of the twelfth century by the Chauhans (also referred to as Chahamanas) of Ajmer. It was under the Tomaras and Chauhans that Delhi became an important commercial centre. Many rich Jaina merchants lived in the city and constructed several temples. Coins minted here, called *dehliwal*, had a wide circulation.



Map 1
Selected Sultanate cities of Delhi, thirteenth-fourteenth centuries.

The transformation of Delhi into a capital that controlled vast areas of the subcontinent started with the foundation of the Delhi Sultanate in the beginning of the thirteenth century. Take a look at Table 1 again and identify the five dynasties that together made the Delhi Sultanate.

The Delhi Sultans built many cities in the area that we now know as Delhi. Look at Map 1 and locate Dehli-i Kuhna, Siri and Jahanpanah.

Reprint 2024-25

THE RULERS OF DELHI

Table 1

RAJPUT DYNASTIES	
Tomaras	**Early twelfth century–1165**
Ananga Pala	1130–1145
Chauhans	**1165–1192**
Prithviraj Chauhan	1175–1192
EARLY TURKISH RULERS	**1206–1290**
Qutbuddin Aybak	1206–1210
Shamsuddin Iltutmish	1210–1236
Raziyya	1236–1240
Ghiyasuddin Balban	1266–1287
KHALJI DYNASTY	**1290–1320**
Jalaluddin Khalji	1290–1296
Alauddin Khalji	1296–1316
TUGHLUQ DYNASTY	**1320–1414**
Ghiyasuddin Tughluq	1320–1324
Muhammad Tughluq	1324–1351
Firuz Shah Tughluq	1351–1388
SAYYID DYNASTY	**1414–1451**
Khizr Khan	1414–1421
LODI DYNASTY	**1451–1526**
Bahlul Lodi	1451–1489

© NCERT not to be republished

Reprint 2024-25

Understanding Delhi under the Sultans

Histories are known as *tarikh* (singular)/*tawarikh* (plural), in Persian, the language of administration under the Delhi Sultans.

The authors of *tawarikh* were learned men: secretaries, administrators, poets and courtiers, who both recounted events and advised rulers on governance, emphasising the importance of just rule.



Do you think the circle of justice is an appropriate term to describe the relationship between the king and his subjects?

The circle of justice

Fakhr-i Mudabbir wrote in the thirteenth century:

A king cannot survive without soldiers. And soldiers cannot live without salaries. Salaries come from the revenue collected from peasants. But peasants can pay revenue only when they are prosperous and happy. This happens when the king promotes justice and honest governance.

Birthright
Privileges claimed on account of birth. For example, people believed that nobles inherited their rights to govern, because they were born in certain families.

Gender distinctions
Social and biological differences between women and men. Usually, these differences are used to argue that men are superior to women.

Keep the following additional details in mind: (1) the authors of *tawarikh* lived in cities (mainly Delhi) and hardly ever in villages. (2) They often wrote their histories for Sultans in the hope of rich rewards. (3) These authors advised rulers on the need to preserve an "ideal" social order based on **birthright** and **gender distinctions**. Their ideas were not shared by everybody.

In 1236 Sultan Iltutmish's daughter, Raziyya, became Sultan. The chronicler of the age, Minhaj-us-Siraj, recognised that she was more able and qualified than all her brothers. But he was not comfortable at having a queen as ruler. Nor were the nobles happy at her attempts to rule independently. She was removed from the throne in 1240.

Reprint 2024-25

What Minhaj-us-Siraj thought about Raziyya: What other important female rulers of India did?

Minhaj-us-Siraj thought that the queen's rule went against the ideal social order created by God, in which women were supposed to be subordinate to men. He therefore asked: "In the register of God's creation, since her account did not fall under the column of men, how did she gain from all of her excellent qualities?"

On her inscriptions and coins Raziyya mentioned that she was the daughter of Sultan Iltutmish. This was in contrast to the queen Rudramadevi (1262–1289), of the Kakatiya dynasty of Warangal, part of modern Andhra Pradesh. Rudramadevi changed her name on her inscriptions and pretended she was a man. Another queen, Didda, ruled in Kashmir (980–1003). Her title is interesting: it comes from "didi" or "elder sister", an obviously affectionate term given to a loved ruler by her subjects.

? *Express Minhaj's ideas in your own words. Do you think Raziyya shared these ideas? Why do you think it was so difficult for a woman to be a ruler?*

A Closer Look: Administration under the Khaljis and Tughluqs

The consolidation of a kingdom as vast as the Delhi Sultanate needed reliable governors and administrators. Rather than appointing aristocrats and landed chieftains as governors, the early Delhi Sultans, especially Iltutmish, favoured their special slaves purchased for military service, called *bandagan* in Persian. They were carefully trained to man some of the most important political offices in the kingdom. Since they were totally dependent upon their master, the Sultan could trust and rely upon them.

© NCERT not to be republished

Reprint 2024-25

Slaves rather than sons

The Sultans were advised:

A slave, whom one has brought up and promoted, must be looked after for it needs a whole lifetime and good luck to find a worthy and experienced slave. Wise men have said that a worthy and experienced slave is better than a son ...

Can you think of any reason why a slave would be better than a son?

Client
Someone who is under the protection of another; a dependent or hanger-on.

The Khaljis and Tughluqs continued to use *bandagan* and also raised people of humble birth, who were often their **clients**, to high political positions. They were appointed as generals and governors. However, this also introduced an element of political instability.

Slaves and clients were loyal to their masters and patrons, but not to their heirs. Sultans had their own servants. As a result the accession of a new monarch often saw conflict between the old and the new nobility. The patronage of these humble people by the Delhi Sultans also shocked many elites and the authors of Persian *tawarikh* criticised the Delhi Sultans for appointing the "low and base-born" to high offices.

Officials of Sultan Muhammad Tughluq

Sultan Muhammad Tughluq appointed Aziz Khummar, a wine distiller, Firuz Hajjam, a barber, Manka Tabbakh, a cook, and two gardeners, Ladha and Pira, to high administrative posts. Ziyauddin Barani, a mid-fourteenth-century chronicler, reported their appointments as a sign of the Sultan's loss of political judgement and his incapacity to rule.

Why do you think Barani criticised the Sultan?

© NCERT not to be republished

Reprint 2024-25

Like the earlier Sultans, the Khalji and Tughluq monarchs appointed military commanders as governors of territories of varying sizes. These lands were called *iqta* and their holder was called *iqtadar* or *muqti*. The duty of the *muqtis* was to lead military campaigns and maintain law and order in their *iqtas*. In exchange for their military services, the *muqtis* collected the revenues of their assignments as salary. They also paid their soldiers from these revenues. Control over *muqtis* was most effective if their office was not inheritable and if they were assigned *iqtas* for a short period of time before being shifted. These harsh conditions of service were rigorously imposed during the reigns of Alauddin Khalji and Muhammad Tughluq. Accountants were appointed by the state to check the amount of revenue collected by the *muqtis*. Care was taken that the *muqti* collected only the taxes prescribed by the state and that he kept the required number of soldiers.

As the Delhi Sultans brought the hinterland of the cities under their control, they forced the landed chieftains – the *samanta* aristocrats – and rich landlords to accept their authority. Under Alauddin Khalji the state brought the assessment and collection of land revenue under its own control. The rights of the local chieftains to levy taxes were cancelled and they were also forced to pay taxes. The Sultan's administrators measured the land and kept careful accounts. Some of the old chieftains and landlords served the Sultanate as revenue collectors and assessors. There were three types of taxes: (1) on cultivation called *kharaj* and amounting to about 50 per cent of the peasant's produce, (2) on cattle and (3) on houses.

It is important to remember that large parts of the subcontinent remained outside the control of the Delhi Sultans. It was difficult to control distant provinces like Bengal from Delhi and soon after annexing southern India, the entire region became independent. Even in the Gangetic plain, there

There were also other Taxes levied–

1. Khums
2. Zakat
3. Jizyah

*1. **Khums** was Consisted of one-fifth of war booty and one-fifth on mines and treasure trove.*

*2. **Zakat** was one of the religious duties enjoined upon all muslims under which they had to give 40th part of their annual savings to the needy and the travellers. It is often suggested that the practice of paying zakat was started by the Prophet himself and it had been made obligatory for all muslims, who had financial means, to do so. Thus essentially zakat was not a tax to be levied by the rulers. However, during the sultanate period Firoz Shah Tughlaq collected zakat as a regular tax and kept a separate account*

Reprint 2024-25

were forested areas that Sultanate forces could not penetrate. Local chieftains established their rule in these regions. Sometimes rulers like Alauddin Khalji and Muhammad Tughluq could force their control in these areas but only for a short duration.

Chieftains and their fortifications

Ibn Battuta, a fourteenth-century traveller from Morocco, Africa, explained that chieftains sometimes

fortified themselves in mountains, in rocky, uneven and rugged places as well as in bamboo groves. In India the bamboo is not hollow; it is big. Its several parts are so intertwined that even fire cannot affect them, and they are on the whole very strong. The chieftains live in these forests which serve them as ramparts, inside which are their cattle and their crops. There is also water for them within, that is, rain water which collects there. Hence they cannot be subdued except by powerful armies, who entering these forests, cut down the bamboos with specially prepared instruments.

? *Describe the ways in which the chieftains arranged for their defence.*

The Mongols under Genghis Khan invaded Transoxiana in north-east Iran in 1219 and the Delhi Sultanate faced their onslaught soon after. Mongol attacks on the Delhi Sultanate increased during the reign of Alauddin Khalji and in the early years of Muhammad Tughluq's rule. This forced the two rulers to mobilise a large standing army in Delhi which posed a huge administrative challenge.

The Sultanate in the Fifteenth and Sixteenth Centuries

Take a look at Table 1 again. You will notice that after the Tughluqs, the Sayyid and Lodi dynasties ruled

for it although there were instances of even influential people evading this tax. On imports and exports particularly the muslim traders were obliged to pay a two and half percent zakat (alms tax) both under the Delhi Sultans and the Mughals.

*3. **Jizyah** was a tax paid by the non-Muslims who had been given the status of zimmis or protected people by the state. In the Sultanate period initially it was collected along with the land tax (kharaj). But Firuz Shah Tughlaq collected jizya as a separate tax.*

Source:
U.N. Day, 1959, Administrative system of Delhi Sultanat, Kitab Mahal Publishers.

Reprint 2024-25

from Delhi and Agra until 1526. By then, Jaunpur, Bengal, Malwa, Gujarat, Rajasthan and the entire south India had independent rulers who established flourishing states and prosperous capitals. This was also the period which saw the emergence of new ruling groups like the Afghans and the Rajputs.

Some of the states established in this period were small but powerful and extremely well administered. Sher Shah Sur (1540–1545) started his career as the manager of a small territory for his uncle in Bihar and eventually challenged and defeated the Mughal emperor Humayun (1530–1540, 1555–1556). Sher Shah captured Delhi and established his own dynasty. Although the Sur dynasty ruled for only fifteen years (1540–1555), it introduced an administration that borrowed elements from Alauddin Khalji and made them more efficient. Sher Shah's administration became the model followed by the great emperor Akbar (1556–1605) when he consolidated the Mughal Empire.

Imagine



You are a peasant in Alauddin Khalji's or Muhammad Tughluq's reign and you cannot pay the taxes demanded by the Sultan. What will you do?

Let's recall

1. Which ruler first established his or her capital at Delhi?
2. What was the language of administration under the Delhi Sultans?
3. In whose reign did the Sultanate reach its farthest extent?
4. From which country did Ibn Battuta travel to India?

© NCERT not to be republished

Reprint 2024-25

KEYWORDS

iqta

tarikh

garrison

Mongols

gender

kharaj

Let's understand

5. According to the "circle of justice", why was it important for military commanders to keep the interests of the peasantry in mind?

6. What is meant by the "internal" and "external" frontiers of the Sultanate?

7. What were the steps taken to ensure that *muqtis* performed their duties? Why do you think they may have wanted to defy the orders of the Sultans?

Let's discuss

8. Do you think the authors of *tawarikh* would provide information about the lives of ordinary men and women?

9. Raziyya Sultan was unique in the history of the Delhi Sultanate. Do you think women leaders are accepted more readily today?

10. Why were the Delhi Sultans interested in cutting down forests? Does deforestation occur for the same reasons today?

Let's do

11. Find out whether there are any buildings built by the Delhi Sultans in your area. Are there any other buildings in your area that were built between the twelfth and fifteenth centuries? Describe some of these buildings, and draw sketches of them.

© NCERT not to be republished

Reprint 2024-25

4 THE MUGHALS (16th TO 17th CENTURY)



Ruling as large a territory as the Indian subcontinent with such a diversity of people and cultures was an extremely difficult task for any ruler to accomplish in the Middle Ages. Quite in contrast to their predecessors, the Mughals created an empire and accomplished what had hitherto seemed possible for only short periods of time. From the latter half of the sixteenth century, they expanded their kingdom from Agra and Delhi, until in the seventeenth century they controlled nearly all of the subcontinent. They imposed structures of administration and ideas of governance that outlasted their rule, leaving a political legacy that succeeding rulers of the subcontinent could not ignore. Today the Prime Minister of India addresses the nation on Independence Day from the ramparts of the Red Fort in Delhi, the residence of the Mughal emperors.

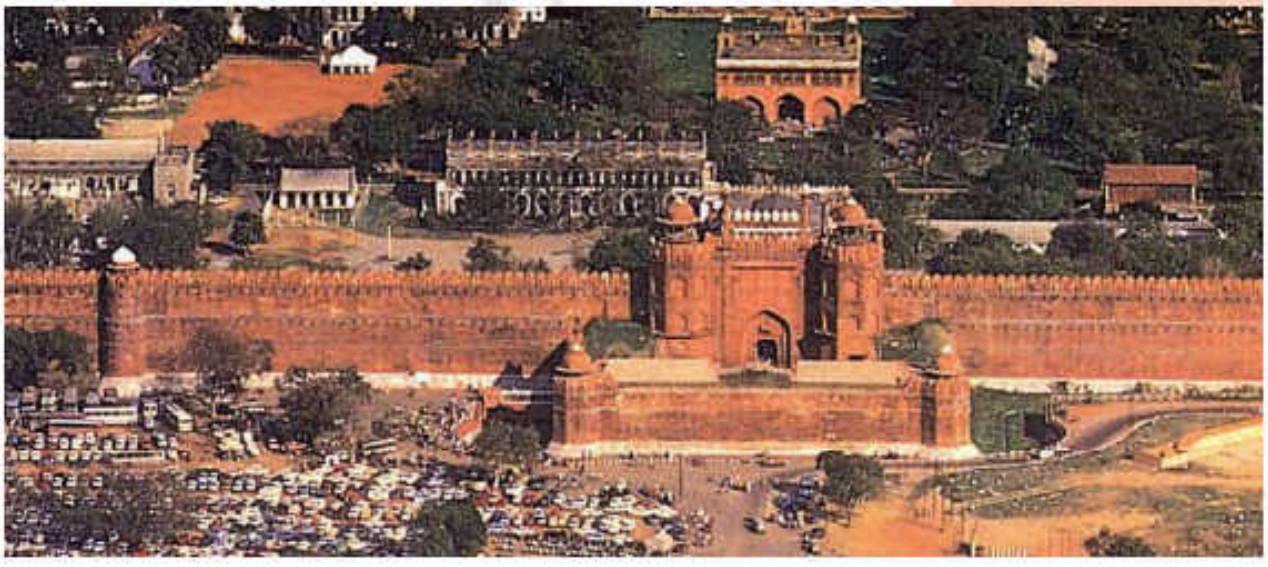


Fig. 1
The Red Fort.

© NCERT not to be republished



Fig. 2
Mughal army on campaign.



Fig. 3
Cannons were an important addition in sixteenth-century warfare. Babur used them effectively in the first battle of Panipat.

Who were the Mughals?

The Mughals were descendants of two great lineages of rulers. From their mother's side they were descendants of Genghis Khan (died 1227), the Mongol ruler who ruled over parts of China and Central Asia. From their father's side, they were the successors of Timur (died 1404), the ruler of Iran, Iraq and modern-day Turkey. However, the Mughals did not like to be called Mughal or Mongol. This was because Genghis Khan's memory was associated with the massacre of innumerable people. It was also linked with the Uzbegs, their Mongol competitors. On the other hand, the Mughals were proud of their Timurid ancestry, not least of all because their great ancestor had captured Delhi in 1398.

They celebrated their genealogy pictorially, each ruler getting a picture made of Timur and himself.

Mughal Military Campaigns

Babur, the first Mughal emperor (1526–1530), succeeded to the throne of Ferghana in 1494 when he was only 12 years old. He was forced to leave his ancestral throne due to the invasion of another Mongol group, the Uzbegs. After years of wandering, he seized Kabul in 1504. In 1526 he defeated the Sultan of Delhi, Ibrahim Lodi, at Panipat and captured Delhi and Agra.

Reprint 2024-25



Map 1
Military campaigns under Akbar and Aurangzeb.

Mughal Traditions of Succession

The Mughals did not believe in the rule of primogeniture, where the eldest son inherited his father's estate. Instead they followed the Mughal and Timurid custom of coparcenary inheritance, or a division of the inheritance amongst all the sons. Which do you think is a fairer division of inheritance: primogeniture or coparcenary?

Mughal Relations with Other Rulers

The Mughal rulers campaigned constantly against rulers who refused to accept their authority. But as the Mughals became powerful many other rulers also joined them voluntarily. The Rajputs are a good example of this. Many of them married their daughters into Mughal families and received high positions. But many resisted as well.

Mughal marriages with the Rajputs

The mother of Jahangir was a Kachhwaha princess, daughter of the Rajput ruler of Amber (modern- day Jaipur). The mother of Shah Jahan was a Rathor princess, daughter of the Rajput ruler of Marwar (Jodhpur).

© NCERT not to be republished

The Sisodiya Rajputs of Mewar refused to accept Mughal authority for a long time. Once defeated, however, they were honourably treated by the Mughals, given their lands *(watan)* back as assignments *(watan jagir)*. The careful balance between defeating but not humiliating their opponents enabled the Mughals to extend their influence over many kings and chieftains. But it was difficult to keep this balance all the time.

Mansabdars and *Jagirdars*

As the empire expanded to encompass different regions, the Mughals recruited diverse bodies of people. From a small nucleus of Turkish nobles (Turanis) they expanded to include Iranians, Indian Muslims, Afghans, Rajputs, Marathas and other groups. Those who joined Mughal service were enrolled as *mansabdars*.

The term *mansabdar* refers to an individual who holds a *mansab*, meaning a position or rank. It was a grading system used by the Mughals to fix (1) rank, (2) salary and (3) military responsibilities. Rank and salary were determined by a numerical value called *zat*. The higher the *zat*, the more prestigious was the noble's position in court and the larger his salary.

The *mansabdar's* military responsibilities required him to maintain a specified number of *sawar* or cavalrymen. The *mansabdar* brought his cavalrymen for review, got them registered, their horses branded and then received money to pay them as salary.

Mansabdars received their salaries as revenue assignments called *jagirs* which were somewhat like *iqtas*. But unlike *muqtis*, most *mansabdars* did not actually reside in or administer their *jagirs*. They only had rights to the revenue of their assignments which was collected for them by their servants while the *mansabdars* themselves served in some other part of the country.

Zat ranking

Nobles with a *zat* of 5,000 were ranked higher than those of 1,000. In Akbar's reign there were 29 *mansabdars* with a rank of 5,000 *zat*; by Aurangzeb's reign the number of *mansabdars* had increased to 79. Would this have meant more expenditure for the state?

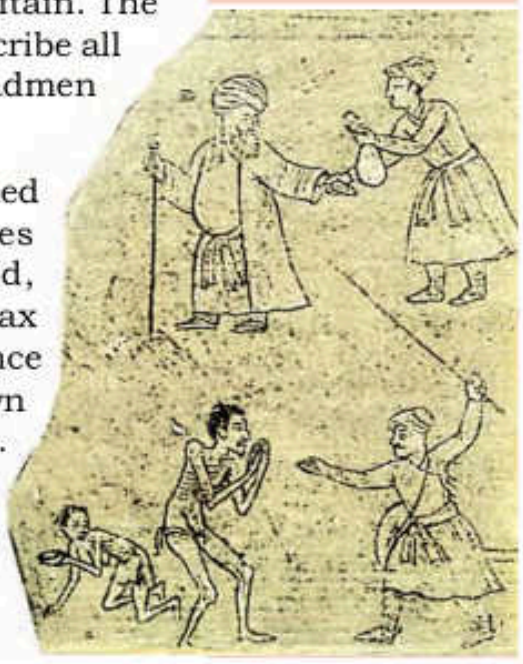
Reprint 2024-25

In Akbar's reign, these *jagirs* were carefully assessed so that their revenues were roughly equal to the salary of the *mansabdar*. By Aurangzeb's reign, this was no longer the case and the actual revenue collected was often less than the granted sum. There was also a huge increase in the number of *mansabdars*, which meant a long wait before they received a *jagir*. These and other factors created a shortage in the number of *jagirs*. As a result, many *jagirdars* tried to extract as much revenue as possible while they had a *jagir*. Aurangzeb was unable to control these developments in the last years of his reign and the peasantry therefore suffered tremendously.



Fig. 4
A mansabdar *on march with his* sawars.

Fig. 5
Details from a miniature from Shah Jahan's reign depicting corruption in his father's administration: (1) a corrupt officer receiving a bribe and (2) a tax-collector punishing poor peasants.



Zabt and Zamindars

The main source of income available to Mughal rulers was tax on the produce of the peasantry. In most places, peasants paid taxes through the rural elites, that is, the headman or the local chieftain. The Mughals used one term – zamindars – to describe all intermediaries, whether they were local headmen of villages or powerful chieftains.

Akbar's revenue minister, Todar Mal, carried out a careful survey of crop yields, prices and areas cultivated for a 10-year period, 1570–1580. On the basis of this data, tax was fixed on each crop in cash. Each province was divided into revenue circles with its own schedule of revenue rates for individual crops. This revenue system was known as *zabt*. It was prevalent in those areas where Mughal administrators could survey the land and keep very careful accounts. This was not possible in provinces, such as Gujarat and Bengal.

Reprint 2024-25

In some areas, the zamindars exercised a great deal of power. The exploitation by Mughal administrators could drive them to rebellion. Sometimes zamindars and peasants of the same caste allied in rebelling against Mughal authority. These peasant revolts challenged the stability of the Mughal Empire from the end of the seventeenth century.

Akbar Nama and *Ain-i Akbari*

Akbar ordered one of his close friends and courtiers, Abul Fazl, to write a history of his reign. Abul Fazl wrote a three-volume history of Akbar's reign, titled *Akbar Nama*. The first volume dealt with Akbar's ancestors and the second volume recorded the events of Akbar's reign. The third volume is the *Ain-i Akbari*. It deals with Akbar's administration, household, army, the revenues and the geography of his empire. It also provides rich details about the traditions and culture of the people living in India. The most interesting aspect about the *Ain-i Akbari* is its rich statistical details about things as diverse as crops, yields, prices, wages and revenues.



Fig. 6
Akbar recieving the Akbar Nama *from Abul Fazl.*

Nur Jahan's influence in Jahangir's court

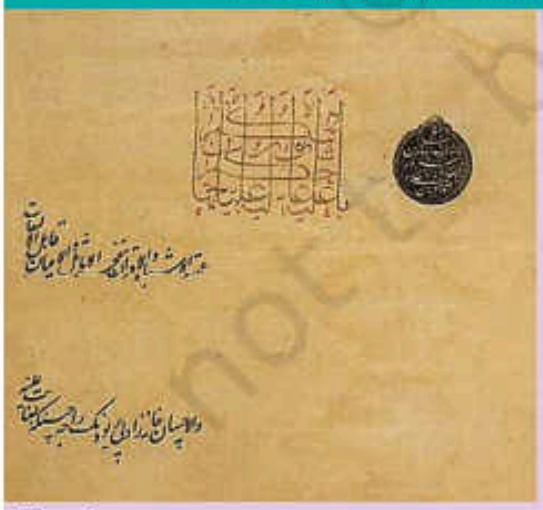


Fig. 7
Nur Jahan's farman.

Mehrunnisa married the Emperor Jahangir in 1611 and received the title Nur Jahan. She remained extremely loyal and supportive to the monarch. As a mark of honour, Jahangir struck silver coins bearing his own titles on one side and on the other the inscription "struck in the name of the Queen Begum, Nur Jahan".

The adjoining document is an order (*farman)* of Nur Jahan. The square seal states, "Command of her most Sublime and Elevated Majesty Nur Jahan Padshah Begum". The round seal states, "by the sun of Shah Jahangir she became as brilliant as the moon; may Nur Jahan Padshah be the lady of the age".

Reprint 2024-25

Sulh-i kul

Jahangir, Akbar's son, described his father's policy of *sulh-i kul* in the following words:

As in the wide expanse of the divine compassion there is room for all classes and the followers of all creeds, so … in his Imperial dominions, which on all sides were limited only by the sea, there was room for the professors of opposite religions, and for beliefs, good and bad, and the road to intolerance was closed. Sunnis and Shias met in one mosque and Christians and Jews in one church to pray. He consistently followed the principle of "universal peace" (sulh-i kul).

The Mughal Empire in the Seventeenth Century and After

The administrative and military efficiency of the Mughal Empire led to great economic and commercial prosperity. International travellers described it as the fabled land of wealth. But these same visitors were also appalled at the state of poverty that existed side by side with the greatest opulence. The inequalities were glaring. Documents from the twentieth year of Shah Jahan's reign inform us that the highest-ranking *mansabdars* were only 445 in number out of a total of 8,000. This small number – a mere 5.6 per cent of the total number of *mansabdars* – received 61.5 per cent of the total estimated revenue of the empire as salaries for themselves and their troopers.

The Mughal emperors and their *mansabdars* spent a great deal of their income on salaries and goods. This expenditure benefited the artisans and peasantry who supplied them with goods and produce. But the scale of revenue collection left very little for investment in the hands of the primary producers – the peasant and the artisan. The poorest amongst them lived from hand to mouth and they could hardly consider investing in additional resources – tools and supplies –

Reprint 2024-25

to increase productivity. The wealthier peasantry and artisanal groups, the merchants and bankers profited in this economic world.

The enormous wealth and resources commanded by the Mughal elite made them an extremely powerful group of people in the late seventeenth century. As the authority of the Mughal emperor slowly declined, his servants emerged as powerful centres of power in the regions. They constituted new dynasties and held the command of provinces like Hyderabad and Awadh. Although they continued to recognise the Mughal emperor in Delhi as their master, by the eighteenth century the provinces of the empire had consolidated their independent political identities.



Imagine

You have inherited a kingdom. (Remember Babur and Akbar were about your age when they became rulers). How would you make your kingdom stable and prosperous?

Let's recall

1. Match the following:

mansab	Marwar
Mongol	Uzbeg
Sisodiya Rajput	Mewar
Rathor Rajput	rank
Nur Jahan	Jahangir

2. Fill in the blanks:

   (a) The five Deccan Sultanates were Berar, Khandesh, Ahmadnagar, _____ and _____.

© NCERT not to be republished

Reprint 2024-25

(b) If *zat* determined a *mansabdar's* rank and salary, *sawar* indicated his _____ .

(c) Abul Fazl, Akbar's friend and counsellor, helped him frame the idea of _____ so that he could govern a society composed of many religions, cultures and castes.

3. What were the central provinces under the control of the Mughals?

4. What was the relationship between the *mansabdar* and the *jagir*?

Let's understand

5. What was the role of the zamindar in Mughal administration?

6. How were the debates with religious scholars important in the formation of Akbar's ideas on governance?

7. Why did the Mughals emphasise their Timurid and not their Mongol descent?

Let's discuss

8. How important was the income from land revenue to the stability of the Mughal Empire?

9. Why was it important for the Mughals to recruit *mansabdars* from diverse backgrounds and not just Turanis and Iranis?

KEYWORDS

Mughal

mansab

jagir

zat

sawar

sulh-i kul

primogeniture

coparcenary

zabt

zamindar

© NCERT not to be republished

Reprint 2024-25

10. Like the Mughal Empire, India today is also made up of many social and cultural units. Does this pose a challenge to national integration?

11. Peasants were vital for the economy of the Mughal Empire. Do you think that they are as important today? Has the gap in the income between the rich and the poor in India changed a great deal from the period of the Mughals?

Let's do

12. The Mughal Empire left its impact on the different regions of the subcontinent in a variety of ways. Find out if it had any impact in the city, village or region in which you live.

© NCERT not to be republished

Reprint 2024-25

6 DEVOTIONAL PATHS TO THE DIVINE



You may have seen people perform rituals of worship, or singing *bhajans*, *kirtans* or *qawwalis*, or even repeating the name of God in silence, and noticed that some of them are moved to tears. Such intense devotion or love of God is the legacy of various kinds of bhakti and Sufi movements that have evolved since the eighth century.

The Idea of a Supreme God

Before large kingdoms emerged, different groups of people worshipped their own gods and goddesses. As people were brought together through the growth of towns, trade and empires, new ideas began to develop. The idea that all living things pass through countless cycles of birth and rebirth performing good deeds and bad came to be widely accepted. Similarly, the idea that all human beings are not equal even at birth gained ground during this period. The belief that social privileges came from birth in a "noble" family or a "high" caste was the subject of many learned texts.

Many people were uneasy with such ideas and turned to the teachings of the Buddha or the Jainas according to which it was possible to overcome social differences and break the cycle of rebirth through personal effort. Others felt attracted to the idea of a Supreme God who could deliver humans from such bondage if approached with devotion (or bhakti). This idea, advocated in the *Bhagavadgita*, grew in popularity in the early centuries of the Common Era.

The beginning of Bhakti

Worship of certain deities, which became a central feature of later Hinduism, gained in importance. These deities included Shiva, Vishnu, and goddesses such as Durga. These deities were worshipped through Bhakti, an idea that became very popular at this time. Bhakti is generally understood as a person's devotion to his or her chosen deity. Anybody, whether rich or poor, belonging to the so-called 'high' or 'low' castes, man or woman, could follow the path of Bhakti. The idea of Bhakti is present in the Bhagavad Gita, a sacred book of the Hindus.

© NCERT not to be republished



Fig. 1
A page from a south Indian manuscript of the Bhagavad Gita.

Shiva, Vishnu and Durga as supreme deities came to be worshipped through elaborate rituals. At the same time, gods and goddesses worshipped in different areas came to be identified with Shiva, Vishnu or Durga. In the process, local myths and legends became a part of the Puranic stories, and methods of worship recommended in the Puranas were introduced into the local cults. Eventually the Puranas also laid down that it was possible for devotees to receive the grace of God regardless of their caste status. The idea of bhakti became so popular that even Buddhists and Jainas adopted these beliefs.



You can observe this process of local myths and legends receiving wider acceptance even today. Can you find some examples around you?

Bhakti in South India – Nayanars and Alvars

The seventh to ninth centuries saw the emergence of new religious movements, led by the Nayanars (saints devoted to Shiva) and Alvars (saints devoted to Vishnu) who came from all castes including those considered "untouchable" like the Pulaiyar and the Panars. They were sharply critical of the Buddhists and Jainas and preached ardent love of Shiva or Vishnu as the path to salvation. They drew upon the ideals of love and heroism as found in the Sangam literature (the earliest example of Tamil literature, composed during the early centuries of the Common Era) and blended them with the values of bhakti. The Nayanars and Alvars went from place to place composing exquisite poems in praise of the deities enshrined in the villages they visited, and set them to music.

Reprint 2024-25

Nayanars and Alvars

There were 63 Nayanars, who belonged to different social backgrounds, such as potters, "untouchable" workers, peasants, hunters, soldiers, Brahmanas and chiefs. The best known among them were Appar, Sambandar, Sundarar and Manikkavasagar. There are two sets of compilations of their songs – *Tevaram* and *Tiruvacakam.*

There were 12 Alvars, who came from equally divergent backgrounds, the best known being Periyalvar, his daughter Andal, Tondaradippodi Alvar and Nammalvar. Their songs were compiled in the *Divya Prabandham.*

Hagiography
Writing of saints' lives.

Between the tenth and twelfth centuries, the Chola and Pandya kings built elaborate temples around many of the shrines visited by the saint-poets, strengthening the links between the bhakti tradition and temple worship. This was also the time when their poems were compiled. Besides, **hagiographies** or religious biographies of the Alvars and Nayanars were also composed. Today we use these texts as sources for writing histories of the bhakti tradition.

Fig. 2
A bronze image of Manikkavasagar.



The devotee and the Lord

This is a composition of Manikkavasagar:

Into my vile body of flesh
You came, as though it were a temple of gold,
And soothed me wholly and saved me,
O Lord of Grace, O Gem most Pure,
Sorrow and birth and death and illusion
You took from me, and set me free.
O Bliss! O Light! I have taken refuge in You,
And never can I be parted from You.

? *How does the poet describe his relationship with the deity?*

Reprint 2024-25

Philosophy and Bhakti

Shankara, one of the most influential philosophers of India, was born in Kerala in the eighth century. He was an advocate of Advaita or the doctrine of the oneness of the individual soul and the Supreme God which is the Ultimate Reality. He taught that Brahman, the only or Ultimate Reality, was formless and without any attributes. He considered the world around us to be an illusion or *maya*, and preached renunciation of the world and adoption of the path of knowledge to understand the true nature of Brahman and attain salvation.

Ramanuja, born in Tamil Nadu in the eleventh century, was deeply influenced by the Alvars. According to him the best means of attaining salvation was through intense devotion to Vishnu. Vishnu in His grace helps the devotee to attain the bliss of union with Him. He propounded the doctrine of Vishishtadvaita or qualified oneness in that the soul even when united with the Supreme God remained distinct. Ramanuja's doctrine greatly inspired the new strand of bhakti which developed in north India subsequently.



Try and find out more about the ideas of Shankara or Ramanuja.

Basavanna's Virashaivism

We noted earlier the connection between the Tamil bhakti movement and temple worship. This in turn led to a reaction that is best represented in the Virashaiva movement initiated by Basavanna and his companions like Allama Prabhu and Akkamahadevi. This movement began in Karnataka in the mid-twelfth century. The Virashaivas argued strongly for the equality of all human beings and against Brahmanical ideas about caste and the treatment of women. They were also against all forms of ritual and idol worship.

© NCERT not to be republished

Reprint 2024-25

Virashaiva *vachanas*

These are *vachanas* or sayings attributed to Basavanna:

The rich,
Will make temples for Shiva.
What shall I,
A poor man,
Do?

My legs are pillars,
The body the shrine,
The head a cupola
Of gold.

Listen, O Lord of the meeting rivers,
Things standing shall fall,
But the moving ever shall stay.

? *What is the temple that Basavanna is offering to God?*

Bhakti Movement in the Decean

From the thirteenth to the seventeenth centuries, Maharashtra saw a great number of saint-poets, whose songs in simple Marathi continue to inspire people. The most important among them were Dnyaneshwar (Gyaneshwar), Namdev, Eknath and Tukaram as well as women like Sakhubai and the family of Chokhamela, who belonged to the "untouchable" Mahar caste. This regional tradition of bhakti focused on the Vitthala (a form of Vishnu) temple in Pandharpur, as well as on the notion of a personal god residing in the hearts of all people.

These saint-poets rejected all forms of ritualism, outward display of piety and social differences based on birth. In fact, they even rejected the idea of renunciation and preferred to live with their families, earning their livelihood like any other person, while humbly serving fellow human beings in need. A new humanist idea emerged as they insisted that bhakti

The Vaishnava poet-saints of Maharashtra, such as Jnaneshwar, Namadeva, Eknath and Tukaram were devotees of lord Vitthala. Devotion around lord Vitthala gave rise to the Varkari sect which lay emphasis on an annual pilgrimage to Pandharpur. The cult of Vitthala emerged as a powerful mode of devotion and was very popular amongst the people.

Reprint 2024-25

lay in sharing others' pain. As the famous Gujarati saint Narsi Mehta said, "They are Vaishnavas who understand the pain of others."

Questioning the social order

This is an *abhang* (Marathi devotional hymn) of Sant Tukaram:

He who identifies
with the battered and the beaten
Mark him as a saint
For God is with him

He holds
Every forsaken man
Close to his heart
He treats
A slave
As his own son

Says Tuka
I won't be tired
to repeat again
Such a man
Is God
In person.

Here is an *abhang* composed by Chokhamela's son:

You made us low caste,
Why don't you face that fact, Great Lord?
Our whole life – left-over food to eat.
You should be ashamed of this.

You have eaten in our home.
How can you deny it?
Chokha's (son) Karmamela asks
Why did you give me life?

? *Discuss the ideas about the social order expressed in these compositions.*

© NCERT not to be republished

Reprint 2024-25

Nathpanthis, Siddhas and Yogis

A number of religious groups that emerged during this period criticised the ritual and other aspects of conventional religion and the social order, using simple, logical arguments. Among them were the Nathpanthis, Siddhacharas and Yogis. They advocated renunciation of the world. To them the path to salvation lay in meditation on the formless Ultimate Reality and the realisation of oneness with it. To achieve this, they advocated intense training of the mind and body through practices like *yogasanas*, breathing exercises and meditation. These groups became particularly popular among "low" castes. Their criticism of conventional religion created the ground for devotional religion to become a popular force in northern India.



Fig. 3
A fireside gathering of ascetics.

Islam and Sufism

The *sants* had much in common with the Sufis, so much so that it is believed that they adopted many ideas of each other. Sufis were Muslim mystics. They rejected outward religiosity and emphasised love and devotion to God and compassion towards all fellow human beings.

Islam propagated strict monotheism or submission to one God. In the eighth and ninth centuries, religious scholars developed different aspects of the Holy Law (Shariat) and theology of Islam. While the religion of Islam gradually became more complex, Sufis provided it with an additional dimension that favoured a more personal devotion to God. The Sufis often rejected the elaborate rituals and codes of behaviour demanded by Muslim religious scholars. They sought union with God much as a lover seeks his beloved with a disregard for

Reprint 2024-25

the world. Like the saint-poets, the Sufis too composed poems expressing their feelings, and a rich literature in prose, including anecdotes and fables, developed around them. Among the great Sufis of Central Asia were Ghazzali, Rumi and Sadi. Like the Nathpanthis, Siddhas and Yogis, the Sufis too believed that the heart can be trained to look at the world in a different way. They developed elaborate methods of training using *zikr* (chanting of a name or sacred formula), contemplation, *sama* (singing), *raqs* (dancing), discussion of parables, breath control, etc., under the guidance of a master or *pir*. Thus emerged the *silsilas*, a spiritual genealogy of Sufi teachers, each following a slightly different method (*tariqa*) of instruction and ritual practice.



Fig. 4
Mystics in ecstasy.

In Kashmir, the Rishi order of Sufism flourished in the 15th and 16th centuries. This order was established by Sheikh Nuruddin Wali also known as Nund Rishi and had a deep impact on the life of the people in Kashmir. A number of shrines dedicated to Rishi saints can be found in many parts of Kashmir.

Reprint 2024-25

A large number of Sufis from Central Asia settled in Hindustan from the eleventh century onwards. This process was strengthened with the establishment of the Delhi Sultanate (Chapter 3), when several major Sufi centres developed all over the subcontinent. The Chishti *silsila* was among the most influential orders. It had a long line of teachers like Khwaja Muinuddin Chishti of Ajmer, Qutbuddin Bakhtiar Kaki of Delhi, Baba Farid of Punjab, Khwaja Nizamuddin Auliya of Delhi and Bandanawaz Gisudaraz of Gulbarga.



Fig. 5
A page from a manuscript of the Quran, *Deccan, late fifteenth century.*

Hospice
House of rest for travellers, especially one kept by a religious order.

The Sufi masters held their assemblies in their *khanqahs* or **hospices**. Devotees of all descriptions including members of the royalty and nobility, and ordinary people flocked to these *khanqahs*. They discussed spiritual matters, sought the blessings of the saints in solving their worldly problems, or simply attended the music and dance sessions.

Often people attributed Sufi masters with miraculous powers that could relieve others of their illnesses and troubles. The tomb or *dargah* of a Sufi saint became a place of pilgrimage to which thousands of people of all faiths thronged.



Fig. 6
Devotees of all backgrounds visit Sufi shrines.

Reprint 2024-25

Finding the Lord

Jalaluddin Rumi was a great thirteenth-century Sufi poet from Iran who wrote in Persian. Here is an excerpt from his work:

He was not on the Cross of the Christians. I went to the Hindu temples. In none of them was there any sign. He was not on the heights or in the lowlands ... I went to the Kaaba of Mecca. He was not there. I asked about him from Avicenna the philosopher. He was beyond the range of Avicenna ... I looked into my heart. In that, his place, I saw him. He was in no other place.

New Religious Developments in North India

The period after the thirteenth century saw a new wave of the bhakti movement in North India. This was an age when Islam, Brahmanical Hinduism, Sufism, various strands of bhakti, and the Nathpanths, Siddhas and Yogis influenced one another. We saw that new kingdoms (Chapters 2, 3 and 4) were emerging, and people were taking up new professions and finding new roles for themselves. Such people, especially craftspersons, peasants, traders and labourers, thronged to listen to these new saints and spread their ideas.



Fig. 7
Chaitanyadeva, a sixteenth-century bhakti saint from Bengal, preached selfless devotion to Krishna-Radha. In the picture you see a group of his followers engaged in ecstatic dancing and singing.

Some of them like Kabir and Baba Guru Nanak rejected all orthodox religions. Others like Tulsidas and Surdas accepted existing beliefs and practices but wanted to make these accessible to all. Tulsidas conceived of God in the form of Rama. Tulsidas's composition, the *Ramcharitmanas*, written in Awadhi (a language used in eastern Uttar Pradesh), is important both as an

Reprint 2024-25



Map 1
Major bhakti saints and the regions associated with them.

The essence of Shankaradeva's devotion came to be known as Eka Sarana Nama Dharma *(supreme surrender to the One). The teachings of Shankaradeva were based on the* Bhagavad Gita *and* Bhagavata Purana. *He also encouraged the establishment of* satra *or monasteries for transmission of knowledge. His major compositions included* Kirtana-ghosha.

expression of his devotion and as a literary work. Surdas was an ardent devotee of Krishna. His compositions, compiled in the *Sursagara*, *Surasaravali* and *Sahitya Lahari*, express his devotion. Also contemporary was Shankaradeva of Assam (late fifteenth century) who emphasised devotion to Vishnu, and composed poems and plays in Assamese. He began the practice of setting up *namghars* or houses of recitation and prayer, a practice that continues to date.

This tradition also included saints like Dadu Dayal, Ravidas and Mirabai. Mirabai was a Rajput princess married into the royal family of Mewar in the sixteenth century. Mirabai became a disciple of Ravidas, a saint from a caste considered "untouchable". She was

© NCERT not to be republished

Reprint 2024-25

An important contribution of Bhakti saints was towards the development of music. Jayadeva of Bengal composed the Gita Govinda in Sanskrit, each song composed in a particular raga and tala. A significant impact that these saints had on music was the use of bhajan, kirtan *and* abhang. *These songs which emphasised on emotional experience had a tremendous appeal to the common people.*

devoted to Krishna and composed innumerable *bhajans* expressing her intense devotion. Her songs also openly challenged the norms of the "upper" castes and became popular with the masses in Rajasthan and Gujarat.

A unique feature of most of the saints is that their works were composed in regional languages and could be sung. They became immensely popular and were handed down orally from generation to generation. Usually the poorest, most deprived communities and women transmitted these songs, often adding their own experiences. Thus the songs as we have them today are as much a creation of the saints as of generations of people who sang them. They have become a part of our living popular culture.

Beyond the Rana's palace

This is a song composed by Mirabai:

Ranaji, I have left your norms of shame,
and false decorum of the princely life.
I have left your town.
And yet Rana why have you kept up
enmity against me?
Rana you gave me a cup of poison.
I drank it laughing.
Rana I will not be destroyed by you.
And yet Rana why have you kept up
enmity against me?

? *Why do you think Mirabai left the Rana's palace?*



Fig. 8
Mirabai.

Reprint 2024-25

A Closer Look: Kabir

Kabir, who probably lived in the fifteenth-sixteenth centuries, was one of the most influential saints. He was brought up in a family of Muslim *julahas* or weavers settled in or near the city of Benares (Varanasi). We have little reliable information about his life. We get to know of his ideas from a vast collection of verses called *sakhis* and *pads* said to have been composed by him and sung by wandering *bhajan* singers. Some of these were later collected and preserved in the *Guru Granth Sahib*, *Panch Vani* and *Bijak*.

In search of the True Lord

Here is a composition of Kabir:

O Allah-Ram present in all living beings
Have mercy on your servants, O Lord!

Why bump your head on the ground,
Why bathe your body in water?
You kill and you call yourself "humble"
But your vices you conceal.

Twenty-four times the Brahmana keeps the ekadasi fast
While the Qazi observes the Ramzan
Tell me why does he set aside the eleven months
To seek spiritual fruit in the twelfth?

Hari dwells in the East, they say
And Allah resides in the West,
Search for him in your heart, in the heart of your heart;
There he dwells, Rahim-Ram.



Fig. 9
Kabir working on a loom.

? *In what ways are the ideas in this poem similar to or different from those of Basavanna and Jalaluddin Rumi?*

© NCERT not to be republished

Kabir's teachings were based on a complete, indeed vehement, rejection of the major religious traditions. His teachings openly ridiculed all forms of external worship of both Brahmanical Hinduism and Islam, the pre-eminence of the priestly classes and the caste system. The language of his poetry was a form of spoken Hindi widely understood by ordinary people. He also sometimes used cryptic language, which is difficult to follow.

Kabir believed in a formless Supreme God and preached that the only path to salvation was through bhakti or devotion. Kabir drew his followers from among both Hindus and Muslims.

A Closer Look: Baba Guru Nanak

We know more about Baba Guru Nanak (1469-1539) than about Kabir. Born at Talwandi (Nankana Sahib in Pakistan), he travelled widely before establishing a centre at Kartarpur (Dera Baba Nanak on the river Ravi). A regular worship that consisted of the singing of his own hymns was established there for his followers. Irrespective of their former creed, caste or gender, his followers ate together in the common kitchen (*langar*). The sacred space thus created by Baba Guru Nanak was known as *dharmsal*. It is now known as Gurdwara.

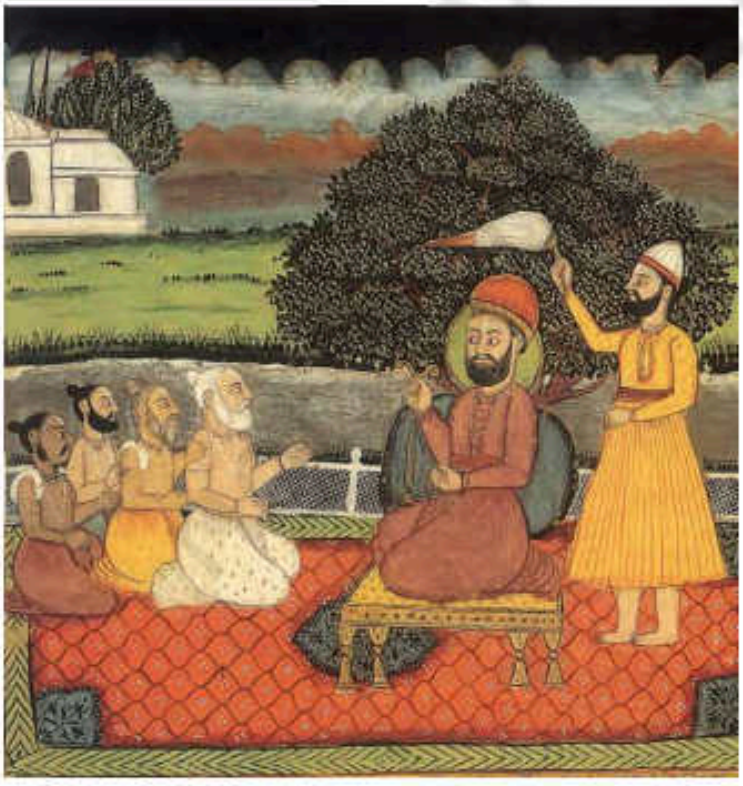


Fig. 10
Baba Guru Nanak as a young man, in discussion with holy men.

Before his death in 1539, Baba Guru Nanak appointed one of his followers as his successor. His name was Lehna but he came to be known as Guru Angad, signifying that he was a part of Baba Guru Nanak himself. Guru Angad compiled the compositions of Baba Guru Nanak, to which he added his own in

Reprint 2024-25

a new script known as Gurmukhi. The three successors of Guru Angad also wrote under the name of "Nanak" and all of their compositions were compiled by Guru Arjan in 1604. To this compilation were added the writings of other figures like Shaikh Farid, Sant Kabir, Bhagat Namdev and Guru Tegh Bahadur. In 1706, this compilation was authenticated by Guru Tegh Bahadur's son and successor, Guru Gobind Singh. It is now known as *Guru Granth Sahib*, the holy scripture of the Sikhs.



Fig. 11
An early manuscript of the Guru Granth Sahib.

The number of Baba Guru Nanak's followers increased through the sixteenth century under his successors. They belonged to a number of castes but traders, agriculturists, artisans and craftsmen predominated. This may have something to do with Baba Guru Nanak's insistence that his followers must be householders and should adopt productive and useful occupations. They were also expected to contribute to the general funds of the community of followers.

By the beginning of the seventeenth century, the town of Ramdaspur (Amritsar) had developed around the central Gurdwara called Harmandar Sahib (Golden Temple). It was virtually self-governing and modern historians refer to the early-seventeenth-century Sikh community as 'a state within the state'. The Mughal emperor Jahangir looked upon them as a potential threat and he ordered the execution of Guru Arjan in 1606. The Sikh movement began to get politicised in the seventeenth century, a development which culminated in the institution of the *Khalsa* by Guru Gobind Singh in 1699. The community of the Sikhs, called the *Khalsa Panth*, became a political entity.

The changing historical situation during the sixteenth and seventeenth centuries influenced the development of the Sikh movement. The ideas

Reprint 2024-25

of Baba Guru Nanak had a huge impact on this development from the very beginning. He emphasised the importance of the worship of one God. He insisted that caste, creed or gender was irrelevant for attaining liberation. His idea of liberation was not that of a state of inert bliss but rather the pursuit of active life with a strong sense of social commitment. He himself used the terms *nam*, *dan* and *isnan* for the essence of his teaching, which actually meant right worship, welfare of others and purity of conduct. His teachings are now remembered as *nam-japna*, *kirt-karna* and *vand-chhakna*, which also underline the importance of right belief and worship, honest living, and helping others. Thus, Baba Guru Nanak's idea of equality had social and political implications. This might partly explain the difference between the history of the followers of Baba Guru Nanak and the history of the followers of the other religious figures of the medieval centuries, like Kabir, Ravidas and Dadu, whose ideas were very similar to those of Baba Guru Nanak.



Imagine

You are attending a meeting where a saint is discussing the caste system. Relate the conversation.

Let's recall

1. Match the following:

The Buddha	*namghar*
Shankaradeva	worship of Vishnu
Nizamuddin Auliya	questioned social differences
Nayanars	Sufi saint
Alvars	worship of Shiva

Reprint 2024-25

2. Fill in the blanks:

   (a) Shankara was an advocate of _____.

   (b) Ramanuja was influenced by the _____.

   (c) _____, _____ and _____ were advocates of Virashaivism.

   (d) _____ was an important centre of the Bhakti tradition in Maharashtra.

3. Describe the beliefs and practices of the Nathpanthis, Siddhas and Yogis.

4. What were the major ideas expressed by Kabir? How did he express these?

Let's understand

5. What were the major beliefs and practices of the Sufis?

6. Why do you think many teachers rejected prevalent religious beliefs and practices?

7. What were the major teachings of Baba Guru Nanak?

Let's discuss

8. For either the Virashaivas or the *sants* of Maharashtra, discuss their attitude towards caste.

9. Why do you think ordinary people preserved the memory of Mirabai?

KEYWORDS

Virashaivism

bhakti

Sufi

khanqah

© NCERT not to be republished

Reprint 2024-25

Let's do

10. Find out whether in your neighbourhood there are any *dargahs*, *gurudwaras* or temples associated with saints of the bhakti tradition in your neighbourhood. Visit any one of these and describe what you see and hear.

11. For any of the saint-poets whose compositions have been included in this chapter, find out more about their works, noting down other poems. Find out whether these are sung, how they are sung, and what the poets wrote about.

12. There are several saint-poets whose names have been mentioned but their works have not been included in the chapter. Find out more about the language in which they composed, whether their compositions were sung, and what their compositions were about.

© NCERT not to be republished

Reprint 2024-25

7 THE MAKING OF REGIONAL CULTURES



One of the commonest ways of describing people is in terms of the language they speak. When we refer to a person as a Tamil or an Oriya, this usually means that he or she speaks Tamil or Oriya and lives in Tamil Nadu or Orissa. We also tend to associate each region with distinctive kinds of food, clothes, poetry, dance, music and painting. Sometimes we take these identities for granted and assume that they have existed from time immemorial. However, the frontiers separating regions have evolved over time (and in fact are still changing). Also, what we understand as regional cultures today are often the product of complex processes of intermixing of local traditions with ideas from other parts of the subcontinent. As we will see, some traditions appear specific to some regions, others seem to be similar across regions, and yet others derive from older practices in a particular area, but take a new form in other regions.

?

Find out how many states have been created in the last 10 years. Is each of these states a region?

The Cheras and the Development of Malayalam

Let us begin by looking at an example of the connection between language and region. The Chera kingdom of Mahodayapuram was established in the ninth century in the south-western part of the peninsula, part of the present-day Kerala. It is likely that Malayalam was spoken in this area. The rulers introduced the Malayalam language and script in their inscriptions. In fact, this is one of the earliest examples of the use of a regional language in official records in the subcontinent.

© NCERT not to be republished



Fig. 1
An early Kerala inscription, composed in Malayalam.

At the same time, the Cheras also drew upon Sanskritic traditions. The temple theatre of Kerala, which is traced to this period, borrowed stories from the Sanskrit epics. The first literary works in Malayalam, dated to about the twelfth century, are directly indebted to Sanskrit. Interestingly enough, a fourteenth-century text, the *Lilatilakam*, dealing with grammar and poetics, was composed in Manipravalam – literally, "diamonds and corals" referring to the two languages, Sanskrit and the regional language.

Find out when the language(s) you speak at home were first used for writing.

Rulers and Religious Traditions: The Jagannatha Cult

In other regions, regional cultures grew around religious traditions. The best example of this process is the cult of Jagannatha (literally, lord of the world, a name for Vishnu) at Puri, Orissa. To date, the local tribal people make the wooden image of the deity, which suggests that the deity was originally a local god, who was later identified with Vishnu.



Fig. 2
The icons of Balabhadra, Subhadra and Jagannatha, palm-leaf manuscript, Orissa.

In the twelfth century, one of the most important rulers of the Ganga dynasty, Anantavarman, decided to erect a temple for Purushottama Jagannatha at Puri. Subsequently, in 1230, king Anangabhima III dedicated his kingdom to the deity and proclaimed himself as the "deputy" of the god.

Reprint 2024-25

As the temple gained in importance as a centre of pilgrimage, its authority in social and political matters also increased. All those who conquered Orissa, such as the Mughals, the Marathas and the English East India Company, attempted to gain control over the temple. They felt that this would make their rule acceptable to the local people.



Fig. 3
Jagannatha temple, Puri.

The Rajputs and Traditions of Heroism

In the nineteenth century, the region that constitutes most of present-day Rajasthan, was called Rajputana by the British. While this may suggest that this was an area that was inhabited only or mainly by Rajputs, this is only partly true. There were (and are) several groups who identify themselves as Rajputs in many areas of northern and central India. And of course, there are several peoples other than Rajputs who live in Rajasthan. However, the Rajputs are often recognised as contributing to the distinctive culture of Rajasthan.



Fig. 4
Prince Raj Singh of Bikaner.

These cultural traditions were closely linked with the ideals and aspirations of rulers. From about the eighth century, most of the present-day state of Rajasthan was ruled by various Rajput families. Prithviraj (Chapter 2) was one such ruler. These rulers cherished the ideal of the hero who fought valiantly, often choosing death on the battlefield rather than face defeat. Stories about Rajput heroes were recorded in poems and songs, which were recited by specially trained minstrels.

Reprint 2024-25

These preserved the memories of heroes and were expected to inspire others to follow their example. Ordinary people were also attracted by these stories – which often depicted dramatic situations, and a range of strong emotions – loyalty, friendship, love, valour, anger, etc.

Did women find a place within these stories? Sometimes women are depicted as following their heroic husbands in both life and death – there are stories about the practice of *sati* or the immolation of widows on the funeral pyre of their husbands. So those who followed the heroic ideal often had to pay for it with their lives.



Map 1
Regions discussed in this chapter.

© NCERT not to be republished

Beyond Regional Frontiers: The Story of *Kathak*

If heroic traditions can be found in different regions in different forms, the same is true of dance. Let us look at the history of one dance form, Kathak, now associated with several parts of north India. The term *kathak* is derived from *katha*, a word used in Sanskrit and other languages for story. The *kathaks* were originally a caste of story-tellers in temples of north India, who embellished their performances with gestures and songs. Kathak began evolving into a distinct mode of dance in the fifteenth and sixteenth centuries with the spread of the bhakti movement. The legends of Radha-Krishna were enacted in folk plays called *rasa lila*, which combined folk dance with the basic gestures of the *kathak* story-tellers.

Under the Mughal emperors and their nobles, Kathak was performed in the court, where it acquired its present features and developed into a form of dance with a distinctive style. Subsequently, it developed in two traditions or *gharanas*: one in the courts of Rajasthan (Jaipur) and the other in Lucknow. Under the patronage of Wajid Ali Shah, the last Nawab of Awadh, it grew into a major art form. By the third quarter of the nineteenth century, it was firmly entrenched as a dance form not only in these two regions, but in the adjoining areas of present-day Punjab, Haryana, Jammu and Kashmir,



Fig. 5
Dance class, Lakshmana temple, Khajuraho.

?

Find out whether there are traditions of heroes/heroines in your town or village. What are the qualities associated with them? In what ways are these similar to or different from the heroic ideals of the Rajputs?

Reprint 2024-25

CLASSICAL
Historically, the term refers to the great works of art and literature, which had been produced in ancient Greece during the 5th and 4th centuries BCE. This was also the period when Greece witnessed the rise of Athens to a pre-eminent position that culminated in the spectacular conquests of Alexander in the near and Middle East up to the frontiers of India.

Source-
Dictionary of History for Schools (Trilingual), 2017, NCERT

Bihar and Madhya Pradesh. Emphasis was laid on intricate and rapid footwork, elaborate costumes, as well as on the enactment of stories.

Kathak, like several other cultural practices, was viewed with disfavour by most British administrators in the nineteenth and twentieth centuries. However, it survived and continued to be performed by courtesans, and was recognised as one of the six "classical" forms of dance in the country after independence.

"Classical" dances

The question of defining any art form as "classical" is often quite complicated. Do we define something as classical if it deals with a religious theme? Or do we consider it classical because it appears to require a great deal of skill acquired through long years of training? Or is it classical because it is performed according to rules that are laid down, and variations are not encouraged? These are questions we need to think about. It is worth remembering that many dance forms that are classified as "folk" also share several of the characteristics considered typical of "classical" forms. So, while the use of the term "classical" may suggest that these forms are superior, this need not always be literally true.

Other dance forms that are recognised as classical at present are:

Bharatanatyam (Tamil Nadu)

Kathakali (Kerala)

Odissi (Odisha)

Kuchipudi (Andhra Pradesh)

Manipuri (Manipur)



Fig. 6
Kathak dancers, a court painting.

Find out more about any one of these dance forms.

Reprint 2024-25

Painting for Patrons: The Tradition of Miniatures

Another tradition that developed in different ways was that of miniature painting. Miniatures (as their very name suggests) are small-sized paintings, generally done in water colour on cloth or paper. The earliest miniatures were on palm leaves or wood. Some of the most beautiful of these, found in western India, were used to illustrate Jaina texts. The Mughal emperors Akbar, Jahangir and Shah Jahan patronised highly skilled painters who primarily illustrated manuscripts containing historical accounts and poetry. These were generally painted in brilliant colours and portrayed court scenes, scenes of battle or hunting, and other aspects of social life. They were often exchanged as gifts and were viewed only by an exclusive few – the emperor and his close associates.



Fig. 7
Akbar resting during a hunt, Mughal miniature.

With the decline of the Mughal Empire, many painters moved out to the courts of the emerging regional states (see also Chapter 8). As a result Mughal artistic tastes influenced the regional courts of the Deccan and the Rajput courts of Rajasthan. At the same time, they retained and developed their distinctive characteristics. Portraits of rulers and court scenes came to be painted, following the Mughal example. Besides, themes from mythology and poetry were depicted at centres such as Mewar, Jodhpur, Bundi, Kota and Kishangarh.

Another region that attracted miniature paintings was the Himalayan foothills around the modern-day state of Himachal Pradesh. By the late seventeenth

Reprint 2024-25



Fig. 8
Maharana Ram Singh II playing holi. Rajput miniature, Kota.

century, this region had developed a bold and intense style of miniature painting called Basohli. The most popular text to be painted here was Bhanudatta's *Rasamanjari*. Nadir Shah's invasion and the conquest of Delhi in 1739 resulted in the migration of Mughal artists to the hills to escape the uncertainties of the plains. Here they found ready patrons which led to the founding of the Kangra school of painting. By the mid-eighteenth century the Kangra artists developed a style which breathed a new spirit into miniature painting. The source of inspiration was the Vaishnavite traditions. Soft colours including cool blues and greens, and a lyrical treatment of themes distinguished Kangra painting.



Fig. 9
Krishna, Radha and her companion, Pahari miniature, Kangra.

Remember that ordinary women and men painted as well — on pots, walls, floors, cloth — works of art that have

Reprint 2024-25

occasionally survived, unlike the miniatures that were carefully preserved in palaces for centuries.

A Closer Look: Bengal

The Growth of a Regional Language

As we saw at the outset, we often tend to identify regions in terms of the language spoken by the people. So, we assume that people in Bengal always spoke Bengali. However, what is interesting is that while Bengali is now recognised as a language derived from Sanskrit, early Sanskrit texts (mid-first millennium BCE) suggest that the people of Bengal did not speak Sanskritic languages. How, then, did the new language emerge?

From the fourth-third centuries BCE, commercial ties began to develop between Bengal and Magadha (south Bihar), which may have led to the growing influence of Sanskrit. During the fourth century, the Gupta rulers established political control over north Bengal and began to settle Brahmanas in this area. Thus, the linguistic and cultural influence from the mid-Ganga valley became stronger. In the seventh century, the Chinese traveller Xuan Zang observed that languages related to Sanskrit were in use all over Bengal.

From the eighth century, Bengal became the centre of a regional kingdom under the Palas (Chapter 2). Between the fourteenth and sixteenth centuries, Bengal was ruled by Sultans who were independent of the rulers in Delhi (Chapter 3). In 1586, when Akbar

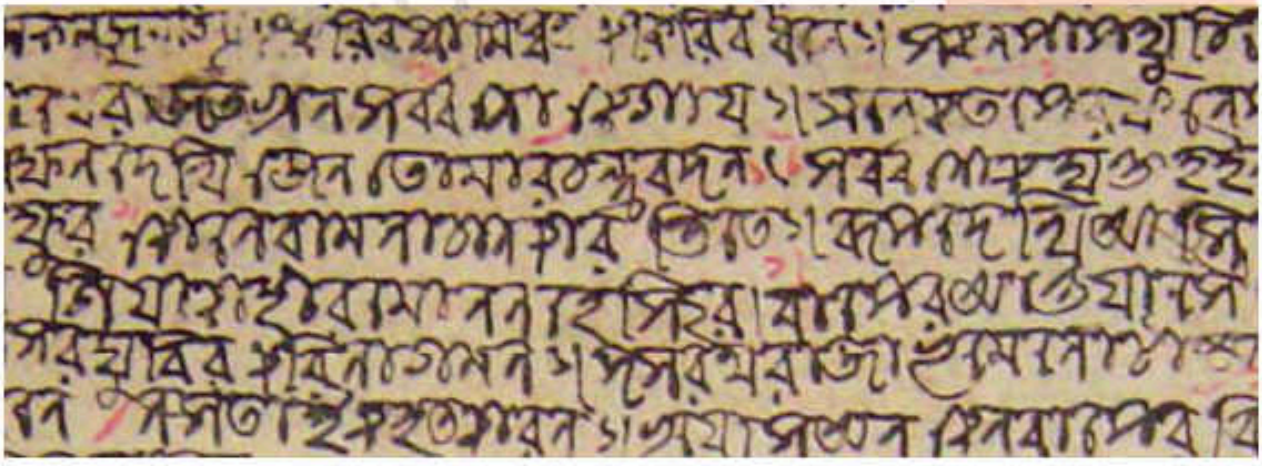


Fig. 10
A page from a palm-leaf manuscript of the earliest Bengali Ramayana.

Reprint 2024-25

conquered Bengal, it formed the nucleus of the Bengal *suba*. While Persian was the language of administration, Bengali developed as a regional language.

In fact, by the fifteenth century the Bengali group of dialects came to be united by a common literary language based on the spoken language of the western part of the region, now known as West Bengal. Thus, although Bengali is derived from Sanskrit, it passed through several stages of evolution. Also, a wide range of non-Sanskrit words, derived from a variety of sources including tribal languages, Persian, and European languages, have become a part of modern Bengali.

Early Bengali literature may be divided into two categories – one indebted to Sanskrit and the other independent of it. The first includes translations of the Sanskrit epics, the Mangalakavyas (literally auspicious poems, dealing with local deities) and bhakti literature, such as the biographies of Chaitanyadeva, the leader of the Vaishnava bhakti movement (Chapter 6).

The second includes Nath literature, such as the songs of Maynamati and Gopichandra, stories concerning the worship of Dharma Thakur, and fairy tales, folk tales and ballads.

Maynamati, Gopichandra and Dharma Thakur

The Naths were ascetics who engaged in a variety of yogic practices.

This particular song, which was often enacted, described how Maynamati, a queen, encouraged her son Gopichandra to adopt the path of asceticism in the face of a variety of obstacles.

Dharma Thakur is a popular regional deity, often worshipped in the form of a stone or a piece of wood.

The texts belonging to the first category are easier to date, as several manuscripts have been found indicating that they were composed between the

Reprint 2024-25

late fifteenth and mid-eighteenth centuries. Those belonging to the second category circulated orally and cannot be precisely dated. They were particularly popular in eastern Bengal, where the influence of Brahmanas was relatively weak.

Pirs and Temples

From the sixteenth century, people began to migrate in large numbers from the less fertile western Bengal to the forested and marshy areas of south-eastern Bengal. As they moved eastwards, they cleared forests and brought the land under rice cultivation. Gradually, local communities of fisherfolk and shifting cultivators, often tribals, merged with the new communities of peasants.

This coincided with the establishment of Mughal control over Bengal with their capital in the heart of the eastern delta at Dhaka. Officials and functionaries received land and often set up mosques that served as centres for religious transformation in these areas.

The early settlers sought some order and assurance in the unstable conditions of the new settlements. These were provided by community leaders, who also functioned as teachers and adjudicators and were sometimes ascribed with supernatural powers. People referred to them with affection and respect as *pirs*.

This term included saints or Sufis and other religious personalities, daring colonisers and deified soldiers, various Hindu and Buddhist deities and even **animistic** spirits. The cult of *pirs* became very popular and their shrines can be found everywhere in Bengal.

Bengal also witnessed a temple-building spree from the late fifteenth century, which culminated in the nineteenth century. We have seen (Chapter 2) that temples and other religious structures were often built by individuals or groups who were becoming powerful – to both demonstrate their power and proclaim their piety. Many of the modest brick



Why do you think the second category of texts was not written down?

Pir
A Persian word meaning a spiritual guide.

Animism
Attribution of living soul to plants, inanimate objects, and natural phenomena.

Reprint 2024-25